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Competencies for Financial Aid Leaders in Higher Education

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CAPSTONE

Submitted in Partial Fulfillment of the Requirements

For the Degree of Doctor of Education, Ed.D.
Interdisciplinary Leadership, Higher Education Concentration

Governors State University
University Park, IL

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By

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ABSTRACT

In the continuously evolving higher education landscape, financial aid leaders play a pivotal role in advancing institutional success and improving student outcomes. However, limited research exists on the specific competencies required for effective financial aid leadership. This quantitative study investigated the professional competencies deemed critical for successful leadership among financial aid leaders at public colleges and universities in the United States. Grounded in a skills-based leadership framework, the study examined how financial aid leaders perceive the importance of various professional competencies, how these perceptions differ based on individual and institutional characteristics, and how such competencies are developed. Data was collected through an online survey and analyzed using descriptive statistics, independent samples *t* tests, and one-way ANOVA. Findings revealed that financial aid leaders ranked the six assessed competency areas in the following order of importance: *Career Development*, *Technical Proficiency*, *Laws and Regulations*, *Leadership Skills*, *Customer Service*, and *Business of Education*. Statistically significant differences emerged based on certain independent variables. The results of this study provide actionable insights for targeted professional development and succession planning, offering a valuable framework for institutions and associations to strengthen leadership capacity within the financial aid profession.

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This capstone is not only a reflection of my own efforts, but also of the community that made it possible. I am deeply thankful to each of you who walked with me on this path.

TABLE OF CONTENTS

LIST OF TABLES viii

LIST OF FIGURES ix

LIST OF APPENDICES x

CHAPTER I 1

INTRODUCTION 1

Background 2

Statement of the Problem 6

Purpose and Audience 7

Research Questions 8

Significance 9

Definition of Terms 10

Organization of Study 12

CHAPTER II 13

LITERATURE REVIEW 13

Overview of Financial Aid 14

History of Financial Aid 14

Impact of Financial Aid 16

Contemporary Issues and Regulations 17

Organizational Structure, Role Clarity, and Succession Planning 20

Organizational Structure 20

Role Clarity 21

Succession Planning 23

Competency Frameworks 24

Leadership Competencies 24

Higher Education Competencies 26

Financial Aid Competencies 29
Competency Development 32
Conceptual Framework 33
Summary 34
CHAPTER III 36
METHODOLOGY 36
Research Design and Rationale for Methodology 37
Participant Selection 38
Instrumentation and Data Collection 40
Data Analysis 42
Research Question 1 46
Research Question 2 46
Research Question 3 48
Biases 48
Ethical Considerations 49
Summary 49
CHAPTER IV 51
FINDINGS 51
Participant Characteristics 52
Research Question 1 55
Research Question 2 56
Years of Experience 57
Institutional Type 60
Institutional Size 63
Institutional Region 66
Staff Size 69

Gender Identity 72
Race/Ethnicity 75
Age 78
Research Question 3 81
Laws and Regulations 81
Career Development 82
Leadership Skills 83
Customer Service 84
Technical Proficiency 85
Business of Education 86
Summary 87
CHAPTER V 90
DISCUSSION 90
Review of Key Findings 91
Participant Characteristics 91
Research Question 1 92
Research Question 2 94
Research Question 3 96
Limitations 100
Implications for Practice 101
Future Research 106
Conclusion 108
REFERENCES 109
APPENDICES 120

LIST OF TABLES

Table 1: Data Analysis Strategies for Research Questions 43

Table 2: Variable List for Research Question Two 47

Table 3: Participant Characteristics Response Distribution 52

Table 4: Mean Scores of Competency Areas 55

Table 5: Summary of One-Way ANOVA - Years of Experience 58

Table 6: Summary of Independent Samples *t* test - Institutional Type 61

Table 7: Summary of One-Way ANOVA - Institutional Size 64

Table 8: Summary of One-Way ANOVA - Institutional Region 67

Table 9: Summary of One-Way ANOVA - Staff Size 70

Table 10: Summary of Independent Samples *t* test - Gender Identity 73

Table 11: Summary of Independent Samples *t* test - Race/Ethnicity 76

Table 12: Summary of One-Way ANOVA - Age 78

Table 13: Methods and Resources for Competency Development in Laws and Regulations 82

Table 14: Methods and Resources for Competency Development in Career Development 83

Table 15: Methods and Resources for Competency Development in Leadership Skills 84

Table 16: Methods and Resources for Competency Development in Customer Service 85

Table 17: Methods and Resources for Competency Development in Technical Proficiency 86

Table 18: Methods and Resources for Competency Development in Business of Education 87

Table 19: Summary of Significant Results 89

LIST OF FIGURES

Figure 1: NASFAA's Financial Aid Competency Framework 31

LIST OF APPENDICES

APPENDIX A: Survey Questionnaire 121

APPENDIX B: Institutional Review Board 128

APPENDIX C: Outreach Email 129

CHAPTER I

INTRODUCTION

The realm of higher education is nuanced and complex, and institutions consistently face new, ongoing, and emerging challenges. Increased cost and marketization of higher education have contributed to changing expectations and attitudes among today's students; consequently, institutions continue to confront issues related to student persistence, retention, and graduation (Guilbault, 2016). In recent years, higher education institutions have struggled with enrollment, federal and state funding, and increased stop-out rates (Conley & Massa, 2022). As these concerns persist, strategic enrollment management (SEM) has become a heightened priority. Efforts to group admissions, financial aid, registration, and retention departments began in the 1970s, uniting key units that influence student decisions to enroll, persist, and graduate (Henderson, 2017). This integration of operational areas contributed to SEM efforts and provided a framework for identifying and marketing institutional strengths—not only to attract individuals to specific institutions but also to expand upon academic programs and offer students need- and merit-based financial aid to alleviate the monetary costs of higher education (DeMonbrun & Warshaw, 2020). Since its inception, the responsibility for SEM initiatives has broadened, and the roles of administrative and academic personnel have evolved.

One area of evolution pertains to financial aid, which has shifted from a supportive role in access and choice to a primary tool for recruitment and the maximization of institutional revenue (Ort, 2000). Financial factors emerge in conversations with staff, administrators, and campus partners within higher education, as they consider the enrollment and financial health of an institution, and it is vital that institutions understand the factors influencing student enrollment and completion. Financial aid significantly influences institutional choice, student persistence

and retention rates, and degree attainment (Olbrecht et al., 2016; Nguyen et al., 2019). The net price of higher education—the amount that students and their families must pay for their education after accounting for discounts, grants, scholarships, and other non-repayable aid—affects students' decisions to enroll, persist, and complete their degrees (Scott-Clayton, 2015). According to Olbrecht et al. (2016), "offering students merit-based financial aid—even in small amounts—helps keep them in college" (p. 12). Given the importance of financial aid to institutional and student success, it is essential for higher education institutions to attract and retain skilled financial aid officers to oversee the education, awarding, and disbursement of student financial aid. Scott-Clayton (2015) emphasizes this point, asserting that "…the day-to-day work of financial aid professionals is critically important to promoting college access and success" (p. 15). The significant role that financial aid offices play in the broader context of higher education warrants further study in this area.

Background

Developing from philanthropic support provided as far back as the mid-1600s (Fuller, 2014), the concept of financial aid has grown remarkably in scope and scale. During the 2023-2024 award year, undergraduate and graduate students received over $256 billion in federal student aid assistance in the form of grants, federal loans, federal tax benefits, and federal work-study (Ma et al., 2024). With the substantial expansion of financial aid programs and provisions came increased structure and new laws governing their operations. Financial aid is subject to stringent regulation, and professionals within this sector must remain acutely aware of the continuously evolving policies, parameters, and procedures to ensure compliance.

One such regulation is 34 CFR § 668.16 (Administrative Capability, 2023), requiring that higher education institutions demonstrate administrative capability to retain eligibility for Title

IV federal financial aid. The National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA, 2020) describes administrative capability as a broadly applied concept referencing an "institution's demonstrated compliance with law and regulation, and its capacity to comply by demonstrating adequate numbers of properly trained staff and by having formal policies and procedures" (p. 2). Contemporary issues within the realm of financial aid or higher education at large can strain an institution's ability to exhibit adequate levels of administrative capability.

Employee retention has been a pervasive challenge across higher education for several years (Marshall et al., 2016). The issue continues to compound, with NASFAA (2023a) noting that many financial aid offices are currently operating at reduced capacity, struggling with turnover rates, expressing concern over administrative capability and service delivery to students, having trouble finding or hiring qualified individuals, or a combination of these issues. In the financial aid sector specifically, institutions experienced an average loss of 2.65 full-time equivalent (FTE) administrators to resignation during the 2021–2022 award year (NASFAA, 2023a)—an increase from prior years.

Moreover, financial aid offices must navigate a complex regulatory landscape, including frequent changes to federal and state policies. For example, the FAFSA Simplification Act enacted through the Consolidated Appropriations Act (2022), and the Financial Value Transparency and Gainful Employment (FVT/GE) Act amending parts 600 and 668 of title 34 of the Code of Federal Regulations (Institutional Eligibility Under the Higher Education act of 1965, as Amended, 2024; Student Assistance General Provisions, 2024) introduced important updates intended to improve transparency and access. However, implementing these changes added layers of complexity and administrative responsibility for financial aid offices and their campus partners.

The current environment is distressing not only for the financial aid profession but also for higher education institutions overall, as the risk of non-compliance increases. While matters of compliance extend beyond the financial aid office (NASFAA, 2020), financial aid leaders are frequently called upon to assist with these issues and must ensure that their offices are well-equipped and properly trained in the education, awarding, and disbursement of student financial aid. Therefore, it is crucial that higher education institutions maintain appropriate staffing levels and reliable operations within their financial aid offices, led by a qualified financial aid leader. This necessity calls for a closer examination of the criteria that define "qualified."

Competencies are defined as the knowledge, skills, abilities, behaviors, or other characteristics an individual must demonstrate to effectively perform in an occupational role, function, or situation (U.S. Office of Personnel Management, n.d.). Financial aid leaders must often balance a variety of responsibilities that are essential for effective leadership and the delivery of financial aid services. In addition to efficient and compliant administration of federal, state, and institutional financial aid programs, financial aid leaders must ensure that both they and their staff are trained in best practices and remain informed about changes in legislation and policy. Furthermore, they are often tasked with developing and maintaining financial budgets, creating strategies to enhance student access to and awareness of educational funding options, and analyzing relevant data. Skills-based leadership emphasizes the knowledge and competencies essential for effective leadership, highlighting a leader-centered perspective that underscores individual capabilities (Northouse, 2015); by possessing certain competencies, financial aid leaders may be better positioned to fulfill these responsibilities. The question then becomes how those competencies are detected.

Higher education associations serve institutions and their constituents by promoting best

practices, providing professional development, fostering collaboration, and offering networking opportunities for members of the educational community. Several higher education associations have produced competency models and documents to guide professionals in their skill and knowledge development. Resources have been issued by the American Association of Collegiate Registrars and Admissions Officers (AACRAO, n.d.), the National Academic Advising Association (Smith & Cunningham, 2022), the National Association for College Admission Counseling (NACAC, 2000), the National Association of Colleges and Employers (NACE, 2024), and a collaborative listing from the American College Personnel Association and Student Affairs Administrators in Higher Education (ACPA & NASPA, 2014). For those working within the financial aid sector of higher education, individuals often rely on guidance from the National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA). With membership of more than 29,000 financial aid professionals representing 3,000 higher education institutions across the country, NASFAA is the only national, nonprofit association emphasizing "information dissemination, professional development, and legislative and regulatory analysis related to federal student aid programs authorized under Title IV of the Higher Education Act of 1965, as amended" (NASFAA, n.d.-a, para. 1). While NASFAA (2023b) outlines a competency framework for effective practice among financial aid administrators in general, one tailored to leadership-level roles in financial aid does not currently exist. This study sought to fill that void.

Beyond identifying the competencies most essential to the financial aid leader role, this study explored the ways in which those competencies are developed. The findings generated from this study not only identified the competencies valued most by financial aid leaders but also generated practical training and development implications and established pathways for future research. An understanding of essential competencies and the ways in which they are developed

can be analyzed for numerous professions and leadership levels. Future studies may opt to apply similar research methodologies to create or modify existing competency frameworks at other hierarchical levels within the financial aid office or to conduct corresponding research on other units associated with SEM efforts, such as admissions, registration, and retention departments.

Statement of the Problem

Existing scholarly research pertaining to student financial aid primarily investigates its influence on access, enrollment, persistence, graduation, and general student success (Alon, 2011; Britt et al., 2017; Chen & Hossler, 2017; Cornwell et al., 2006; Gross et al., 2007; Haynes, 2008; Heller, 1999; Hossler et al., 2008; Nguyen et al., 2019). However, there is a notable lack of research concerning the roles and competencies of financial aid leaders who supervise the education, awarding, and disbursement of student financial aid, despite the impact of financial aid on achieving both student and institutional objectives. Recent studies examining these concepts were primarily limited to the role, educational needs, and competencies of entry- and mid-level financial aid officers (Lane, 2003; McKinney & Roberts, 2012; Woolf, 2012; Woolf & Martinez, 2013) or entry- and mid-level enrollment management positions within the admissions, financial aid, and registrar sectors (Giblin & Morris, 2021). Although these studies may have included financial aid leaders within their participant samples, they do not specifically focus on this level. This absence of targeted research may result in ineffective hiring practices and inadequately designed professional development initiatives, thereby constraining institutions' abilities to effectively recruit, retain, and support high-performing financial aid leaders.

Earlier studies have explored the roles and perceptions of financial aid leaders (Barry, 1974; Dowling, 1998; Short & Matlock, 1984), but less research has been conducted on the roles and perceptions of financial aid leaders in present contexts. The only recent study identified during

the researcher's review of contemporary literature addressing leadership-level positions within the financial aid sector was Flogaites' (2019) analysis of the behavioral characteristics of financial aid directors and their self-perceptions as educators, leaders, or managers—ultimately finding that most participants within the sample identified as leaders. With the evolution of higher education and consistent changes to regulation governing the administration of student financial aid, as well as the impact of student financial aid and benefits of applying competency frameworks to a profession, there is a clear need to better comprehend and articulate the financial aid leader role.

Purpose and Audience

The purpose of this study was to understand how financial aid leaders perceive the importance of professional competencies to success in their role and how they are developed. Moreover, this study explored whether perceptions differed between financial aid leaders based on certain variables. Specifically, this research explored and ultimately identified the competency areas necessary for effective practice as a financial aid leader through a perception-based, quantitative research study. To respond to this inquiry, data was collected and analyzed through a survey instrument distributed to individuals serving as financial aid leaders at public colleges and universities in the United States.

The primary audience for this research includes individuals working within the financial aid sector. Particularly, this research is valuable for those aspiring to become financial aid leaders by providing a defined set of competencies on which personal and professional development efforts may be focused. Current financial aid leaders may also benefit from this study. Coupled with self-reflective practices, current leaders can identify their own strengths and areas for improvement based on the competencies outlined in this research. Beyond the Financial Aid Office, employers, supervisors, and individuals from other departments may gain a better

understanding of the role and skillset of the financial aid leader and how this position and its responsibilities align with other areas of enrollment management and the larger institution. Those tasked with hiring, developing, and retaining financial aid leaders may find this research useful when evaluating candidates and when structuring training and development opportunities. With the purpose and intended audience established, the next section outlines the research questions that guided this study and provided structure to the data collection and analysis process.

Research Questions

This study was guided by the following research questions:

1. How do financial aid leaders perceive the importance of professional competencies to success in their role?
2. How do financial aid leaders' perceptions of professional competencies differ as a function of:
    - Years of Experience
    - Institutional Type
    - Institutional Size
    - Institutional Region
    - Staff Size
    - Gender Identity
    - Race/Ethnicity
    - Age
3. How are professional competencies for effective practice as a financial aid leader developed?

Significance

While numerous studies have explored the impact of financial aid on key indicators of student success, such as access, academic persistence, and graduation outcomes (Alon, 2011; Britt et al., 2017; Chen & Hossler, 2017; Cornwell et al., 2006; Gross et al., 2007; Haynes, 2008; Heller, 1999; Hossler et al., 2008; Nguyen et al., 2019), there is a gap in material dedicated to the study of professional competencies necessary for financial aid leadership. At a time when post-secondary institutions, especially financial aid offices, are experiencing tremendous change (NASFAA, 2023a), it is vital to have experienced and competent financial aid leaders spearheading their efforts. Moreover, as retirements and resignations continue to affect the higher education sector (Marshall et al., 2016), there is growing urgency to identify and cultivate the competencies needed in the next generation of leaders. Thus, this study carries significant weight and tremendous potential to contribute to the financial aid profession and higher education overall by providing data that may be utilized to improve training and development efforts, expand awareness of this key role, and enrich existing literature with a shaper lens.

While it would benefit current, emerging, and aspiring financial aid leaders to familiarize themselves with all the competencies required for success in the role, this study sought to highlight specific competency areas that individuals situated in this position deem most essential at the leadership level and the ways in which those competencies are refined. This focus allows for targeted development as individuals continue to progress and grow as leaders in the field. Moreover, this research examined in greater detail the perceptions of financial aid leaders themselves, allowing the researcher to gain rich insights from those most familiar with this role and the competencies they identified as instrumental for successful practice.

Definition of Terms

Competency: Knowledge, skills, abilities, behaviors, or other characteristics an individual must demonstrate to effectively perform in an occupational role, function, or situation (U.S. Office of Personnel Management, n.d.).

Competency Area: Groupings of similar or related competencies. The competency areas used in this study were drawn from the six key focus areas outlined in the National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators' (NASFAA) competency framework:

- *Business of Education:* Involves the financial, operational, and strategic functions necessary for managing educational institutions, including budgeting, resource allocation, and institutional planning.
- *Career Development:* Encompasses continuous learning, skill-building, and advancement activities that support career growth and leadership readiness.
- *Customer Service:* Refers to the ability to assist students and families effectively through clear communication, empathy, and responsiveness, particularly in complex or high-stakes situations.
- *Laws and Regulations:* Covers the federal, state, and institutional policies that govern the administration of financial aid, including compliance with Title IV.
- *Leadership Skills:* Represents the knowledge and abilities required to lead teams, influence decision-making, and advance goals within regulatory and institutional contexts.
- *Technical Proficiency:* Involves the use of technology systems and tools needed for accurate, compliant, and efficient financial aid administration.

Federal Student Aid (FSA): A division of the U.S. Department of Education responsible for administering federal student financial aid programs authorized under Title IV.

Financial Aid Leader: The individual holding the highest position within the Financial Aid Office, responsible for overseeing the office and leading all financial aid officers. Although Financial Aid Leaders may also be considered Financial Aid Officers/Administrators, they are viewed as a distinct subgroup for the purpose of this study.

Financial Aid Office: The office within a higher education institution that is responsible for administering student financial aid, including communication, preparation, and disbursement.

Financial Aid Officer/Administrator: Any individual employed within the Financial Aid Office involved in the administering of Student Financial Aid.

Organizational Theory: A framework used to understand how institutions operate, including the structures, relationships, and functions of individuals and departments within the broader organization.

Professional Associations: Membership-based organizations that support practitioners in a specific profession by promoting best practices, providing training and development opportunities, and advocating for the field. Associations referenced in this study include:

- American Association of Collegiate Registrars and Admissions Officers (AACRAO)
- American College Personnel Association (ACPA)
- National Academic Advising Association (NACADA)
- National Association for College Admission Counseling (NACAC)
- National Association of Colleges and Employers (NACE)
- National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA)
- Student Affairs Administrators in Higher Education (NASPA)

Skills-Based Leadership: A leadership approach that emphasizes the development and application of specific competencies and knowledge, rather than relying on inherent traits.

Strategic Enrollment Management (SEM): An institution-wide approach to achieving enrollment, retention, and completion goals through coordination of key departments such as admissions, financial aid, and student support services.

Student Financial Aid: Grant, scholarship, or loan funds received from the government, private organizations, or a higher education institution to help students pay for their education.

Title IV: The section of the Higher Education Act of 1965 that authorizes federal student aid programs, including Pell Grants, Federal Work-Study, and Direct Loans.

Organization of Study

Scholarly literature is deficient in material that features financial aid leaders. This research aimed to clarify the knowledge and skills necessary for success as a financial aid leader, as perceived by those serving in this capacity within their institutional communities. The findings contribute to the field and generate implications for practice, particularly in regard to training and development efforts. This study has been organized into five chapters. Chapter 1 introduced this quantitative study, which evaluated the competencies most valued in practice by financial aid leaders in higher education institutions. The background, problem, purpose, audience, research questions, significance, and definition of terms were conveyed—providing a foundation and overview for the study. Chapter 2 will further enhance understanding through a review of existing, relevant literature, and will outline the framework that guided this study. The methodology for data collection and analysis will be discussed in Chapter 3, followed by a presentation of the study's findings in Chapter 4. The resulting implications and conclusion will be shared in Chapter 5.

CHAPTER II

LITERATURE REVIEW

The central purpose of this study was to understand how financial aid leaders perceive the importance of professional competencies to success in their role and how they are developed. Moreover, this study explored whether perceptions differed between financial aid leaders based on certain variables. With this intention, the researcher sought to contribute to existing literature and scholarly research detailing the role and function of financial aid leaders, support professional development for current, emerging, and aspiring leaders, and inform practices within the profession. Specifically, the study investigated the following research questions:

1. How do financial aid leaders perceive the importance of professional competencies to success in their role?
2. How do financial aid leaders' perceptions of professional competencies differ as a function of:
    - Years of Experience
    - Institutional Type
    - Institutional Size
    - Institutional Region
    - Staff Size
    - Gender Identity
    - Race/Ethnicity
    - Age
3. How are professional competencies for effective practice as a financial aid leader developed?

To achieve these objectives, foundational knowledge related to financial aid must first be established. This chapter begins with an overview of financial aid, including its history, impact, and contemporary issues and regulations that influence the role of financial aid officers. The discussion will then address the importance of organizational structure, role clarity, and succession planning, followed by an exploration of the concept of competencies—both in general terms and as it applies specifically to higher education and financial aid practice. The chapter will conclude with a conceptual framework and summary of the key points discussed.

Overview of Financial Aid

An examination of the history of financial aid, its impact, and contemporary issues and regulations within the financial aid sector—and higher education more broadly—helps situate the role and responsibilities of financial aid leaders, and this important context will assist in framing the remainder of the literature review. Accordingly, this section begins with a brief primer on the history of financial aid.

History of Financial Aid

The history of financial aid is long and storied, with roots tracing back to the mid-1600s. During this period, philanthropic contributions from wealthy benefactors aided economically disadvantaged students in their pursuit of higher education and may be likened to what we consider scholarships in present times (Fuller, 2014). Sponsorship and patronage continued to play a central role in funding higher education and gained momentum during the colonial era, leading to the creation of several endowed scholarships for students. A major shift in student aid occurred in 1944 with the passage of the Servicemen's Readjustment Act—more commonly known as the GI Bill. By providing federal financial assistance and other benefits to veterans returning from World War II, the GI Bill marked the first major federal intervention in student

aid and greatly enhanced access to higher education (McGuinness, 2016; Mumper et al., 2016; Serna, 2019). As noted by Mumper et al. (2016), the introduction of the GI Bill led to a sharp rise in college enrollments, broadening access and diversifying the student population.

This landmark legislation paved the way for future federal involvement in higher education by recognizing the need to support students financially. Fuller (2014) explains that the rapid influx of students caused by the implementation of the GI Bill "…provided impetus for the student financial aid administrator's role" (p. 50). As a result, financial aid offices were expanded, and institutions hired administrative professionals to assist with the management of this program. Further solidifying the need for and importance of financial aid administrators was the passage of the Higher Education Act (HEA) in 1965. Comprised of multiple titles, the HEA authorizes numerous programs and provisions aimed at supporting postsecondary institutions and their students (Kaplin et al., 2020). Of particular importance to the history of financial aid, Title IV of the HEA governs the administration of federal student financial aid programs. Key federal student aid programs, including need-based grants, loans, and work-study initiatives, were instituted through the HEA—fundamentally shaping how students finance their education (Mumper et al., 2016). Other notable initiatives established through the HEA include the Free Application for Federal Student Aid (FAFSA), TRIO programs, Title IX protections, and loan repayment options.

The HEA and its initiatives were designed to streamline the financial aid process and make higher education more accessible to marginalized communities and low-income students. Subsequent amendments to the HEA over the years have expanded and restructured student aid programs, further cementing the federal government's role in funding higher education. Today, federal student aid programs continue to evolve, seeking to meet the growing financial needs of

students while addressing issues such as student loan debt and the rising cost of tuition. The implementation of these programs, policies, and regulations has had a lasting positive impact on students, as highlighted in the following section.

Impact of Financial Aid

The impressive and widespread impact of financial aid is evident by the extensive number of students who receive funding through various federal, state, and institutional programs. According to the National Center for Education Statistics (2023), 87 percent of first-time, full-time undergraduate students at public, four-year institutions receive some form of financial aid to support their educational endeavors. In the 2023-2024 academic year, undergraduate students received an average of $16,360 per full-time equivalent (FTE) student in financial aid, while graduate students received an average of $28,420 per FTE student in financial aid (Ma et al., 2024). This financial support reduces the cost paid by students and their families, alleviating financial burdens and influencing decisions related to institutional choice.

Financial aid also plays a critical role in student persistence and retention. Even modest amounts of financial assistance can strengthen the likelihood that students will return for their sophomore year—a key indicator of persistence and eventual graduation (Olbrecht et al., 2016). Additionally, Nguyen et al. (2019) found that grant aid improves persistence and degree completion by 2 to 3 percent; from a monetary standpoint, an additional $1,000 in grant aid enhances persistence and attainment by 1.5 to 2 percent. Given that an overarching goal of higher education institutions is to cultivate an educated and engaged citizenry through degree attainment, it may be suggested that financial aid has a direct impact on institutions' abilities to fulfill their central missions.

Contemporary Issues and Regulations

When considering ways to maximize the impact of financial aid to support student success, higher education leaders must remain cognizant of contemporary issues and regulations affecting the field. Employee attrition within higher education has been a persistent and significant issue for several years (Marshall et al., 2016). Many employees report feeling overextended, with increasing demands and fewer resources, leading some to leave the profession entirely. Within the financial aid sector, the National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA) (2023a) reported an average loss of 2.65 full-time equivalent (FTE) administrators due to resignation during the 2021-2022 award year. This marked an increase from the average loss of 1 FTE position reported in NASFAA's 2022 update. The ongoing exodus of higher education employees is concerning. Employee attrition—and the subsequent loss of knowledge and expertise—puts institutions at risk of failing to demonstrate administrative capability, a critical requirement for retaining eligibility for Title IV federal financial aid under 34 CFR § 668.16 (Administrative Capability, 2023). Notably, administrative capability extends beyond the financial aid office; it "encompasses the entirety of an institution's compliance," and "adequate numbers of properly trained staff" (NASFAA, 2020, p. 2) are essential. Consequently, it is imperative that financial aid offices are sufficiently equipped to meet the evolving needs of students and maintain institutional compliance.

In addition to demonstrating administrative capability, higher education institutions must comply with a myriad of regulations to maintain eligibility for administering numerous student financial aid programs. Financial aid administrators are responsible for a broad range of duties and interact with multiple stakeholders, including students and families, other campus departments, and the larger community (NASFAA, 2022). Moreover, financial aid offices are

responsible for a wide range of tasks which include verifying selected student files, reviewing reconciliation and over-award reports, evaluating Satisfactory Academic Progress (SAP), monitoring students approaching loan limits, and more (Flogaites, 2019; NASFAA, 2022; Woolf, 2012). Furthermore, they must meet a multitude of reporting requirements, including the annual submission of the Fiscal Operations Report and Application to Participate (FISAP), which is used to apply for Campus-Based Program funding for the upcoming award year and report expenditures from the previous year. Beyond federal regulations, institutions are also subject to state-level requirements and institutional policies. As such, financial aid officers must remain current with the legislative changes repeatedly confronting them.

A recent example of regulatory change is the FAFSA Simplification Act, which was enacted as part of the Consolidated Appropriations Act (2022). The goal of the act was to address long-standing concerns with the HEA Title IV federal student aid application process by streamlining the Free Application for Federal Student Aid (FAFSA) form and expanding eligibility for federal student aid. Despite these intentions, however, the implementation of the legislation faced significant challenges. The American Council on Education (ACE) (2024) published a timeline outlining the considerable issues and errors experienced throughout the rollout of the revised FAFSA, including months-long delays before the FAFSA opened, when FAFSA information was transmitted to institutions, and when FAFSA correction capabilities became available. Moreover, several technical complications emerged following the launch, and implementation challenges had severe consequences, including an 8.8% decline in FAFSA completion nationwide (National College Attainment Network, 2024). The FAFSA Simplification Act and its effects represent just one example of regulatory change that financial aid offices must grapple with, although this may be viewed as a more extreme case.

To ensure that higher education institutions uphold the standards necessary to retain funding eligibility, they are subjected to rigorous audits and program reviews as outlined under 34 CFR § 668.23 (Compliance Audits and Audited Financial Statements, 2023). The U.S. Department of Education's (2024) *Federal Student Aid Handbook*, Volume 2, Chapter 4, specifies the responsibilities required of financial aid officers in fulfilling audit requirements, which focus primarily on compliance audits and financial statement audits conducted annually. These audits assess the adequacy and effectiveness of institutional controls and processes to ensure compliance with applicable laws and regulations. Audit procedures include, but are not limited to, reviews of federal student aid eligibility and disbursement, cohort default rates, and assessments of financial responsibility (U.S. Department of Education, 2024). Ultimately, audit results are published in an official report made available to the public.

Given the complexity and time-consuming nature of compliance responsibilities, financial aid offices require substantial institutional investment in staff, training, and technology to ensure federal funds are managed effectively and in compliance with increasingly intricate Title IV regulations. Failure to comply with these policies and regulations can result in severe consequences, including lawsuits, loss of accreditation, and loss of federal funding. To ensure sustainable and successful practices in the face of employee attrition, regulatory changes, and other unforeseen challenges, higher education leaders would benefit from developing defined competencies for those positioned in financial aid roles. To achieve this objective, as well as to maintain effective operations and ensure that financial aid continues to support student success, a clear understanding of financial aid structures and the roles and responsibilities of financial aid personnel is vital.

Organizational Structure, Role Clarity, and Succession Planning

In today's dynamic environment, organizations must engage in forward-thinking strategies to ensure long-term stability, sustainability, and growth. A broad perspective of the structures and roles within an organization enhances the planning process for training and development initiatives aimed at cultivating the necessary characteristics and skills for success. Without this clarity, departments may experience communication breakdowns, conflicts over procedures, and a decline in morale. Therefore, it is essential that the functions and responsibilities of key roles are clearly defined and understood.

Organizational Structure

Organizational structures of strategic enrollment management (SEM) typically include departments such as admissions, financial aid, records and registration, academic advising, retention programs, career services, and alumni relations. The integration of these diverse units can be viewed as transformational to the student experience (Henderson, 2017). These departments contribute to a comprehensive SEM strategy by recruiting prospective students; aiding new and continuing students through course selection, registration, and financing; monitoring attrition rates and creating programs targeted to underprepared students or potential stop-outs; processing graduations; and providing services for life post-graduation (DeMonbrun & Warshaw, 2020; Harvey-Smith, 2019; Henderson, 2107; Hossler & Kemerer, 1986). These units are often referred to as high-touch areas, because they play a critical role in shaping the holistic student experience, which is a central focus of SEM initiatives.

Compelling arguments support the notion of shared responsibility for enrollment outcomes within higher education institutions. SEM emphasizes a comprehensive approach to student experience, encompassing the entire student lifecycle—from the initial point of contact

to graduation and beyond. The development of SEM has enabled colleges and universities to critically examine various facets of their impact on student success, with the goal of streamlining the flow of student-related information (Harvey-Smith, 2019). According to Henderson (2017), the student journey can be thought of as a "…tangle of relationships where students interact with faculty, staff, and each other as they sort out issues, seek help, and learn to navigate the institution" (p. 148). SEM aims to clarify this complex experience by creating clear, integrated pathways across campus.

While expressions of SEM may differ across institutions due to factors such as institutional mission, resources, geographic location, political environment, financial needs, and academic offerings (Hossler & Kamerer, 1986; Hossler, 2015; Huddleston, 2000), the overarching goal of SEM remains consistent: to establish clear objectives for enrollment, retention, and degree completion in the face of ongoing challenges within the higher education landscape (Harvey-Smith, 2019). Within this framework, financial aid is a crucial component of SEM efforts, as it makes higher education more accessible and affordable. By improving access and affordability, financial aid plays a key role in both attracting prospective students and supporting the retention and graduation of current students.

Role Clarity

In the financial aid field, the job titles of financial aid administrators vary and may include financial aid advisor or counselor, assistant or associate director, and director of financial aid, among others (Giblin & Morris, 2021). Financial aid administrators carry out a broad array of responsibilities that involve supporting students and their families, collaborating with campus departments, and engaging with the broader community (NASFAA, 2022). Responsibilities include providing financial aid information to students and their families, assisting with the

annual completion of the Free Application for Federal Student Aid (FAFSA), and ensuring financial aid packages are clearly explained (NASFAA, 2022; Sanders, 2021; Woolf, 2012). Administrators also communicate the requirements of the financial aid process and eligibility criteria to various student populations (Giblin & Morris, 2021; Woolf, 2012). Moreover, financial aid administrators are responsible for monitoring students' satisfactory academic progress (SAP), constructing cost-of-attendance budgets, reviewing financial aid awards for overages, and tracking changes in student enrollment that may impact eligibility (Sanders, 2021).

According to Giblin and Morris (2021), entry-level financial aid positions primarily involve interpreting departmental policies, assisting with internal operations, and offering direct support to students and families. These roles are typically focused on advising, counseling, assisting, and evaluating the financial aid needs of students. As financial aid administrators progress, their responsibilities shift toward greater oversight, compliance, and collaborative efforts (Giblin & Morris, 2021). In these positions, administrators are tasked with developing policies, making decisions, and providing leadership in the distribution of financial aid. Additionally, more seasoned administrators play a key role in coordinating efforts to assess the effectiveness of financial aid systems. These duties may necessitate partnership with other campus departments, including admissions, the registrar’s office, academic advising, housing and residential life, the bursar’s office, and institutional research (NASFAA, 2022).

Furthermore, financial aid administrators regularly engage in both internal and external collaboration to manage compliance, oversee communication efforts, prepare reports for federal, state, and institutional agencies, and implement institution-wide policies and procedures to ensure adherence to regulatory standards (Giblin & Morris, 2021). While a strong understanding of financial aid practices and clear role definitions are essential for effective administration, a

well-structured approach to succession planning is equally crucial for ensuring organizational continuity and preparing for future leadership transitions.

Succession Planning

The creation of professional development and succession planning systems prioritizes the recruitment and retention of qualified staff. Effective succession planning helps generate a pool of qualified candidates for key organizational positions, while also fostering a culture that promotes ongoing professional and career development (Bolton & Roy, 2004). Effective succession planning can minimize the expenses associated with hiring and onboarding while ensuring leadership continuity, thereby limiting operational disruptions (Bolton & Roy, 2004; Ritchie, 2020). Additionally, succession planning mitigates the loss of knowledge and historical perspective that can occur when employees leave an organization. Bolton and Roy (2004) asserted that succession planning "promotes the continual development of the leadership potential in rank and file and encourages staff ownership of their own professional growth" (p. 589). This focus on internal training and development not only demonstrates commitment to employees but may instill a sense of loyalty, which can positively impact employee retention.

Developing such plans requires a comprehensive understanding of the knowledge, skills, and behaviors essential for effective practice. Furthermore, organizations must identify key leadership positions and prepare potential successors for those roles (Bolton & Roy, 2004). Attributes such as initiative, emotional intelligence, and demonstrated high performance may signal potential leadership candidates. However, Mehrabani and Mohamad (2011) note the fluidity of contemporary work environments, where "organizations are flatter" and "the organizational configuration frequently changes" (p. 371). As a result, instead of focusing on specific people for specific positions, it may be more effective to develop a group of high-

potential employees with broad competencies for leadership roles. This approach underscores the need to identify and outline the core competencies necessary for success.

Competency Frameworks

Recognizing the specific competencies essential for a profession is key to creating pathways and frameworks that support aspiring leaders, while also helping current leaders strengthen their practice and plan for succession effectively. Competencies include the knowledge, skills, abilities, behaviors, and other characteristics an individual must demonstrate to perform well in a particular role, function, or context (U.S. Office of Personnel Management, n.d.). Identifying both strengths and areas for growth is critical for intentional leadership development and offers valuable guidance on the kinds of training individuals should pursue.

Leadership Competencies

Competencies for effective leadership can be identified by evaluating various leadership theories and styles. Kouzes and Posner (2010) outline five practices of exemplary leadership, which include modeling the way, inspiring a shared vision, challenging the process, enabling others to act, and encouraging the heart. These practices overlap with the qualities of authentic leadership described by George (2010), such as understanding one's purpose, practicing solid values, leading with heart, establishing connected relationships, and demonstrating self-discipline. A strong sense of awareness is foundational to authentic leadership. When leaders understand their own values, they can act in ways that are meaningful to themselves and inspiring to others (Boyatzis & McKee, 2005). Leaders must express themselves authentically to build trust and form strong relationships that bind the organization together (Crutchfield & Grant, 2012). They must also remain mindful and use balanced processing when making decisions.

Building on these ideas, shared leadership promotes empowerment, motivation, and a positive, collaborative atmosphere. George (2010) stresses that authentic leaders are not interested in personal power or prestige but instead desire to serve and empower those they lead. Effective leaders demonstrate humility, will, and ambition—not for personal gain, but for the benefit of their organizations. Similarly, Collins (2001, 2010) emphasizes that success should not be attributed to a single individual, but rather to the collective efforts of a community. Participative leadership theory further expands on shared leadership by highlighting the mutual influence between leaders and subordinates in decision-making, which can benefit team development and motivation (Sethuraman & Suresh, 2014). By nurturing shared growth through active listening and community-building, leaders can foster positive change and establish enduring success within their organizations. Additionally, Farrell (2017) recommends incorporating diverse personality types within an organization to support varied opinions, communication styles, and skills.

The theory of servant leadership posits that a leader's main goal is to serve and encourage growth in others. Northouse (2015) explains that servant leaders are ethical and seek to serve the greater good of the organization, community, and society. By doing so, the organization is encouraged to function as a community of individuals who work collectively and share in success (George, 2010). Spears (2002) identified ten characteristics of servant leaders, including listening, empathy, healing, awareness, persuasion, conceptualization, foresight, stewardship, commitment to the growth of people, and building community. Liden et al. (2008) emphasized similar qualities, including conceptualizing, emotional healing, prioritizing followers, helping followers grow and succeed, ethical behavior, empowerment, and creating value for the community. Other scholars have noted that empowerment, humility, integrity, and authenticity

are central to servant leadership (Northouse, 2015). Beyond general leadership theories, it is valuable for individuals to understand and hone competencies deemed important to their specific profession. Several higher education associations have published competency models and other related resources relevant to postsecondary education.

Higher Education Competencies

Higher education associations support institutions and their members by advocating for best practices, providing professional development opportunities, fostering collaboration, and facilitating networking within the academic community. Numerous professional associations in higher education have published resources and guidance related to skills and competencies, including contributions from the American Association of Collegiate Registrars and Admissions Officers, the National Academic Advising Association, the National Association for College Admission Counseling, the National Association of Colleges and Employers, and a joint initiative from the American College Personnel Association and Student Affairs Administrators in Higher Education. While these competency frameworks are not tailored to the financial aid community, the competencies outlined may overlap with those utilized within the field.

The American Association of Collegiate Registrars and Admissions Officers (AACRAO) serves a wide range of professionals in higher education working in various administrative, support, and student service positions. While the association is best known for supporting registrar and admissions professionals, it also provides resources and advocacy for individuals involved in enrollment management, student success, academic affairs, and related fields. AACRAO (n.d.) designed a set of professional competencies and proficiencies to serve as "a living resource that will continue to evolve parallel to the demands of our professions in a dynamic higher education environment" (p. 1). The association explains that the competencies

are applicable to all AACRAO professionals regardless of their functional area, whereas the proficiencies identify specific knowledge and skills associated with Admissions, Enrollment Management, and Records and Academic Services roles. The core competencies, which should be developed and utilized across all AACRAO professions, include change management, collaborative decision-making and consensus-building, diversity and inclusion, holistic and systemic thinking, interpretation and application of institutional and external data, leadership and management, problem solving, professional integrity, communication, technological knowledge, and professional development and contributions to the field (AACRAO, n.d.).

The National Academic Advising Association (NACADA) supports a diverse range of professionals, including academic advisors, retention specialists, career advisors, and faculty members, all of whom play a critical role in helping students succeed academically and professionally. To aid these professionals, NACADA established a framework for academic advisor core competencies that outlines the skills and knowledge necessary to guide students effectively (Smith & Cunningham, 2022). This framework consists of three key components: conceptual, informational, and relational. The conceptual component encompasses the fundamental concepts academic advisors must understand, the informational component includes the knowledge academic advisors must master, and the relational component focuses on the skills academic advisors must demonstrate.

The National Association for College Admission Counseling (NACAC) is a professional organization that represents individuals who guide and advise students seeking higher education. While NACAC's membership is comprised of several professions, many of the association's resources are geared specifically toward high school and college admissions counselors, including their Statement on Counselor Competencies (NACAC, 2000). Both high school and

college admissions counselors should demonstrate exemplary counseling and communication skills; the ability to understand and promote student development and achievement; the ability to facilitate transitions and counsel students toward the realization of their full educational potential; the ability to recognize, appreciate, serve cultural differences and the special needs of students and families; appropriate ethical behavior and professional conduct in the fulfillment of roles and responsibilities; the ability to develop, collect, analyze, and interpret data; and advocacy and leadership in advancing the concerns of students (NACAC, 2000). Additionally, high school counselors should possess and demonstrate the ability to organize and integrate the precollege guidance and counseling component into the total school guidance program, and college admissions counselors should possess and demonstrate the ability to organize and support a college admission counseling program.

The National Association of Colleges and Employers (NACE) serves a wide variety of professionals in higher education and workforce development. This includes individuals in career services, employer relations, recruitment, talent development, and human resources who work to support students' transition from college to the workforce. NACE also supports professionals in admissions, alumni relations, faculty, and HR and recruiting roles within educational institutions. NACE's (2024) career readiness competencies provide a foundation to prepare individuals for success in the workplace, including career and self-development, communication, critical thinking, equity and inclusion, leadership, professionalism, teamwork, and technology.

The American College Personnel Association (ACPA) and Student Affairs Administrators in Higher Education (NASPA) are primarily focusing on student affairs and student development. Both organizations serve a wide range of professionals who are involved in supporting student success, campus life, and overall student development. These two

associations collaborated to form a Professional Competencies Task Force which led efforts to update professional competency areas for student affairs educators (ACPA & NASPA, 2014). The ten professional competency areas presented include personal and educational foundations; values, philosophy, and history; assessment, evaluation, and research; law, policy, and governance; organizational and human resources; leadership; social justice and inclusion; student learning and development; technology; and advising and supporting.

Financial Aid Competencies

Although the recognition of professional competencies has garnered attention in various sectors, limited research has focused specifically on the competencies required for financial aid administrators. Lane (2004) analyzed the competencies and training needs of financial aid administrators and highlighted the top responses. Beginning with the competency ranked most important, the 11 competencies judged as most significant were: 1) possessing high degree of integrity; 2) maintaining ethical behavior in all activities; 3) asking questions; 4) assuming responsibility; 5) possessing listening skills; 6) enjoying helping people; 7) ability to listen and care; 8) ability to multi-task; 9) maintaining a concern for the students and a realistic expectation for the student to fulfill; 10) understanding the concepts of customer service; and 11) treating every customer as an individual.

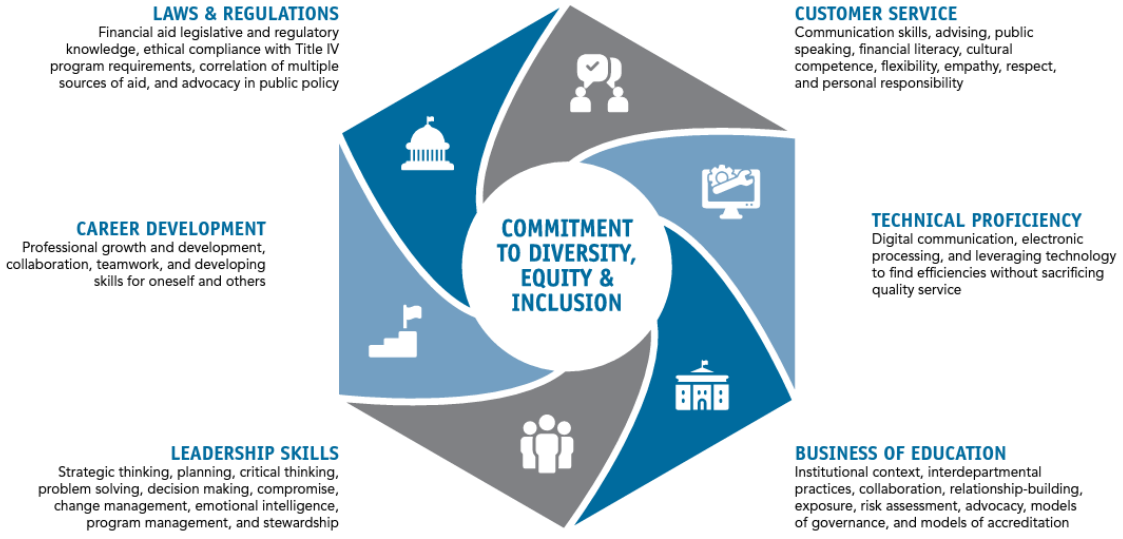
Woolf and Martinez (2013) conducted a survey of 508 financial aid officers in the Western United States to assess both the perceived importance and frequency of use of 30 professional competencies. The competencies rated highest in importance included the ability to provide high-quality customer service, follow rules and policies, work effectively in teams, demonstrate interpersonal skills, and work independently. Notably, the competencies most frequently used closely mirrored those deemed most important. Building on this research, Giblin

and Morris (2021) analyzed job postings for entry- and mid-level positions in enrollment management, spanning financial aid, admissions, and registrar offices. Their findings emphasized the prominence of communication and collaboration as highly sought after skills. These findings highlight the necessity for integration and synergy among functional units to meet broader institutional goals related to enrollment and retention. Giblin and Morris (2021) further underscored the implications for professional development, including the need for clearer role definitions, enhanced communication, and targeted training initiatives.

Founded in 1966, the National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA) serves as the primary professional association for financial aid practitioners in the United States (n.d.-a). Over the decades, NASFAA has played a pivotal role in influencing federal financial aid policy, supporting professional development, and promoting best practices in aid administration. In recognition of the increasing complexity of the field and the growing demands placed on practitioners, NASFAA identified the need for a framework to guide professional development and ensure consistent practice. In response, a comprehensive toolkit was published (NASFAA, 2023b) including a financial aid competency framework comprised of six key focus areas: *Laws and Regulations*, *Career Development*, *Leadership Skills*, *Customer Service*, *Technical Proficiency*, and *Business of Education* (Figure 1). This framework represented a significant step toward professionalizing the field by articulating the knowledge, and skills required for success in financial aid roles. Prior to the release of this framework, the profession lacked a unified set of competencies to inform and standardize practice. While NASFAA's competency framework offers broad guidance for financial aid administrators at large, the present study narrows the focus to investigate competencies specifically valued by financial aid leaders.

Figure 1

NASFAA's Financial Aid Competency Framework



Leadership in financial aid requires a balance of strategic thinking, policy interpretation, team development, and the ability to advocate within institutional and regulatory contexts. A noteworthy contribution to the understanding of financial aid leadership is Flogaites' (2019) study on the behavioral characteristics of financial aid directors and their self-perceptions as educators, leaders, or managers. Participants in Flogaites' (20119) study identified primarily as leaders. Earlier foundational studies by Barry (1974) and Dowling (1998) also emphasized leadership competencies including budgeting, conflict resolution, problem-solving, relationship building, change management, and in-depth knowledge of federal financial aid regulations. Barry (1974) argued that effective financial aid leaders must balance analytical expertise with interpersonal skills to navigate the multifaceted challenges of the role. However, overall, scholarly research on competencies associated with financial aid leadership remains underexplored, highlighting a critical gap that this study sought to address.

Competency Development

Once the competencies required for success in a given profession are identified, efforts must be made to develop them. Professional development opportunities, offered in various formats, play a crucial role in this process. Individuals can enhance their qualifications and skillsets through specialized training, certifications, and formal coursework. These opportunities may be available through online platforms or industry-recognized credentials. For instance, the NASFAA (n.d.-b) offers 16 Professional Credentials, covering topics such as need analysis, verification, packaging, and aid notification, as well as a formal Certified Financial Aid Administrator program where learners can achieve a specialized FAAC designation. These programs equip financial aid professionals with the knowledge and credentials needed to excel in their roles. Additionally, institutions may offer degrees and certificates in higher education, with coursework designed to cultivate well-rounded professionals.

Networking through professional organizations, mentorship programs, and events further supports career growth by expanding professional connections and offering valuable insights. Workshops, webinars, seminars, and conferences also provide opportunities to stay informed about industry trends and engage with peers. Both NASFAA (n.d.-b) and Federal Student Aid (FSA, n.d.) hold annual conferences and offer webinars throughout the year. Many regional financial aid associations also host annual events, fostering additional networking and professional development. Moreover, cross-training or job shadowing within an organization allows individuals to gain hands-on experience and deepen their practical knowledge. Finally, industry-related literature, such as books, journals, articles/blogs, and podcasts, offers accessible resources for ongoing learning. Examples of these types of publications include journals such as *The Journal of Higher Education* and *Journal of Student Financial Aid*, articles/blogs from *The*

Chronicle of Higher Education and *Inside Higher Ed*, and podcasts like NASFAA's (n.d.-c) *Off the Cuff*. By engaging with a combination of these methods, professionals can strengthen the knowledge, skills, and behaviors necessary for effective practice.

Conceptual Framework

At a broad level, this research is grounded by organizational theory, which focuses on the structures and operations of organizations and considers the individuals within the organization, the institutional character, and the dynamics and relationships of individuals and groups across the institution to gain a fuller understanding of how organizations operate. As Dominguez-Whitehead (2018) articulates, this theory is "concerned with individual participants within organizations, the ways in which individuals make sense of the organizational environment, and the overarching ways in which organizations operate" (p. 1694). As members of the larger organization (higher education institution), it is important to understand the role of financial aid leaders. Gaining a deeper understanding of their responsibilities and the competencies necessary for effective financial aid leadership enhances insights into professional development, career progression, and hiring practices.

This study aimed to identify those key competencies and explored how they are developed. Specifically, this research employed a skills-based leadership framework to examine the role of the financial aid leader. Skills-based leadership focuses on the knowledge and competencies needed for effective leadership. Rooted in a leader-centered perspective, this approach highlights the capabilities of individuals rather than relying on intrinsic traits or fixed personality characteristics (Northouse, 2015). A skills-based approach to leadership theory is appealing because of its conceptualization of leadership as a set of abilities that can be learned and developed over time. This perspective broadens access to leadership roles, moving beyond

traditional notions that may equate or restrict leadership to those assumed or perceived to possess certain qualities (Northouse, 2015). Framing leadership in this way can also provide motivation for individuals seeking professional growth—potentially leading to increased empowerment, productivity, and morale within the workplace (Ganta, 2014). By presenting leadership as a learnable and improvable practice, the skills-based approach offers a practical roadmap for both individual development and organizational effectiveness.

The purpose of this study was to discover the core competencies most valued by financial aid leaders. The findings aim to support existing, emerging, and aspiring leaders by identifying targeted areas for growth, both for themselves and for those they lead. Furthermore, understanding how these competencies are developed can help guide training and development initiatives, ultimately strengthening leadership capacity across the financial aid profession. This conceptual framework—grounded in organizational theory and viewed through the lens of skills-based leadership—established a foundation for examining the role of financial aid leaders. It provided a theoretical basis for exploring the knowledge and abilities required for effective leadership and underscored the importance of intentionally developing those competencies within the organizational context of higher education.

Summary

Existing literature offers a strong foundation regarding the history, impact, and regulatory landscape of financial aid in higher education. As the profession continues to evolve, shaped by shifting policies and increasing complexity, it becomes increasingly important to deepen awareness of the roles and responsibilities of financial aid officers. Both individuals and institutions must also understand the competencies essential for effective leadership in this area. Financial aid leaders are charged not only with overseeing the day-to-day operations of their

offices but also with ensuring long-term success through strategic development and succession planning. By applying a skills-based leadership framework, this study provides a focused examination of the professional competencies required for effective practice in financial aid leadership. The findings offer valuable insights that can inform targeted training, professional development, and hiring practices—for both current leaders and those responsible for cultivating or selecting future leadership within the profession.

CHAPTER III

METHODOLOGY

This study aimed to understand how financial aid leaders perceive the importance of professional competencies to success in their role and how they are developed. Moreover, this study explored whether perceptions differed between financial aid leaders based on certain variables. The position of financial aid leader is essential within higher education institutions. This research contributes to existing literature by enhancing understanding of the financial aid leader role and identifying the specific skills, knowledge, and behaviors required for success in this position. Specifically, the study addressed three primary research questions:

1. How do financial aid leaders perceive the importance of professional competencies to success in their role?
2. How do financial aid leaders' perceptions of professional competencies differ as a function of:
    - Years of Experience
    - Institutional Type
    - Institutional Size
    - Institutional Region
    - Staff Size
    - Gender Identity
    - Race/Ethnicity
    - Age
3. How are professional competencies for effective practice as a financial aid leader developed?

Results carry significant implications, especially for training and development. These implications are of particular benefit to current, emerging, and aspiring financial aid leaders, as well as those involved in the hiring process or who interact regularly with individuals in this role. This chapter outlines the research design and rationale, researcher biases, ethical considerations, participant selection, and the data collection and analysis procedures employed in the study.

Research Design and Rationale for Methodology

A quantitative, non-experimental research design was selected for this study. The choice of research design and methodology is largely driven by the research problem or issue being investigated (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). The primary intent of this study was to understand how financial aid leaders perceive the importance of professional competencies to success in their role, explore potential differences in perceptions based on certain factors, and how competencies are developed. A quantitative approach was appropriate for this study due to its ability to provide analytic and objective insights (Asenahabi, 2019). Through quantitative design, numerical data was able to be collected and analyzed to identify trends, compare groups, and detect patterns using statistical techniques (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). Quantitative research frequently uses instruments such as tests, surveys, or questionnaires; in this study, data was collected through a survey distributed to financial aid leaders.

There were several advantages to employing a quantitative research methodology. One benefit was the ability to source data from a larger sample size, which enhanced the generalizability of findings to a broader population (Rahman, 2017). Additionally, quantitative research is often narrow in scope and more easily replicated. Although this study focused on financial aid leaders at public colleges and universities in the United States, its results may offer valuable insights that could be relevant to other institutional types or hierarchical levels within

the financial aid office. Future researchers may also replicate this study in different contexts to examine how financial aid leaders, other financial aid positions, or various roles in higher education and beyond perceive competencies in numerous settings.

Participant Selection

This research focused on how financial aid leaders perceive the importance of professional competencies to success in their roles, as well as the methods utilized to develop those competencies. The sample for this study consisted of financial aid leaders serving at public colleges and universities in the United States. Current leaders can offer unique insights and possess substantial familiarity with the responsibilities and expectations of the position. It is important to note that while the exact title of the financial aid leader may vary, for the purposes of this study, the role was defined as the individual holding the highest position within the Financial Aid Office, responsible for overseeing the office and leading all financial aid officers.

Survey research requires obtaining a sufficient sample that is representative of the population of interest (Ponto, 2015), and simple random sampling provides an equal probability of selection for participants (Omona, 2013). To obtain participants, the researcher used a non-probability, purposive sampling technique. Purposeful sampling is used to select individuals or groups that meet selected criteria and who possess certain traits or qualities (Koerber & McMichael, 2008; Omona, 2013). This technique aims to identify individuals who share specific characteristics relevant to the research topic (Alkassim & Tran, 2016). For this study, a survey was distributed to financial aid leaders at public colleges and universities in the United States. To facilitate targeted and methodologically sound outreach, the researcher employed a systematic, multi-step approach to compile a list of eligible participants. The initial phase of this process involved utilizing the NASFAA Member Directory (NASFAA, n.d.-d), a comprehensive

resource that enables filtering based on parameters such as region, state, school type, and sector. For this research, the researcher specifically used the *school type* filter to identify institutions that fit the criteria of interest. The filters selected included “Public 2-Year,” “Public 4-Year Only,” and “Public 4-Year & Above” institutions based on the study's focus on public colleges and universities in the United States. This yielded a list of 1,833 eligible institutions, which was then exported to an Excel spreadsheet for further organization and refinement.

The next step involved gathering critical contact information necessary for outreach, specifically the name and email address of each institution’s financial aid leader. To do so, the researcher relied on publicly available information, primarily sourced from institutional websites and directories. In cases where individual contact details were unavailable, and to account for potentially outdated information, general financial aid office email addresses were recorded to ensure institutions could still be contacted. This dual approach—obtaining both direct and general contact information—was intended to mitigate potential data reliability issues and maximize the likelihood of participant engagement. Ultimately, the researcher was able to obtain direct contact information, general financial aid office contact information, or both, for 1,743 of the 1,833 eligible institutions. All contact data was collected in compliance with ethical guidelines, using publicly accessible sources. This approach ensured that the outreach process adhered to best practices in participant recruitment while safeguarding individual privacy. This compilation process was a critical component of the study's methodology. It ensured that outreach efforts were comprehensive, data-driven, and appropriately aligned with the study’s research goals, supporting an effective and ethically responsible participant recruitment strategy.

Additionally, persistence in outreach was crucial to ensuring a sufficient response rate, as survey research requires a sample that is representative of the target population (Ponto, 2015).

With contact information for 1,743 institutions compiled, the researcher expected a robust dataset for analysis. It is important to note that in some cases, identical contact information was used across multiple institutions—particularly within institutional systems that include multiple campuses or centralized financial aid operations. As a result, the actual number of potential respondents is likely lower than 1,743; however, the exact number could not be determined.

Instrumentation and Data Collection

The primary instrument used for data collection in this study was a survey questionnaire administered to financial aid leaders at public colleges and universities in the United States (Appendix A). As a research tool, surveys offer several advantages, including cost-efficiency, speed of data collection, the ability to reach a larger sample, increased respondent anonymity, and the potential for more accurate or candid responses compared to interviews (Cummings, n.d.). The goal of this study was to understand how financial aid leaders perceive the importance of professional competencies to success in their role and how they are developed. To address these objectives, the survey included a structured list of competencies for participants to assess. The survey was carefully designed to minimize measurement error and enhance response rates. The researcher ensured the instrument was clearly formatted with a readable font size and logically ordered questions in a non-leading manner (Ponto, 2015). A preliminary question screened for eligibility, ensuring that only financial aid leaders were included in the data analysis. The researcher assumed responsibility for designing the survey, distributing it, collecting and analyzing the data, and reporting the findings.

The content of the survey was based on NASFAA's (2023b) recently published competency framework for financial aid administrators and its six focus areas: *Laws and Regulations*, *Career Development*, *Leadership Skills*, *Customer Service*, *Technical Proficiency*,

and *Business of Education*. Each focus area contains between three and ten specific competencies. These categories and competencies served as the foundation for several of the survey items. Participants rated the importance of each competency to success in their role as a financial aid leader using a 4-point Likert scale: *Not Important, Somewhat Important, Important,* and *Very Important.* For each focus area, respondents also indicated the resources and methods they found most useful for developing the associated competencies. In addition to competency-related questions, the survey gathered contextual information including years of experience, institutional type, institutional size, institutional region, staff size, gender identity, race/ethnicity, and age. These variables were analyzed to identify potential trends and differences in perception.

To evaluate the clarity, estimated completion time, and initial content validity of the survey instrument, a pilot test was conducted with a professional colleague currently serving as a Financial Aid Leader. Pilot testing is helpful for determining whether survey instructions and items are understandable and adequately represent the intended constructs (Dillman et al., 2014). The participant reported that the survey was well-formatted and easy to navigate. SurveyMonkey estimated the completion time to be approximately eight minutes; the participant completed it in seven minutes—aligning with the platform's projection. After completing the survey and reviewing the research questions, the participant affirmed that the instrument was likely to generate sufficient data to address the study's objectives. One key recommendation from the pilot involved consolidating the method/resource response options related to competency development. In response, the number of options was reduced from 16 to 9 to improve clarity and eliminate redundancy.

Prior to data collection, the study was reviewed by the Institutional Review Board (IRB), with approval granted on March 25, 2025 (Appendix B). The survey was administered online via

the SurveyMonkey platform and provided participants with an introductory statement and contact information for questions. The online format supported efficient data collection and real-time monitoring through built-in dashboards. The survey was designed to take no more than 10 minutes to complete and posed minimal risk to participants. Participation was entirely voluntary, and individuals could withdraw at any time by closing the survey.

Recruitment was conducted through an email invitation sent by the researcher (Appendix C), which included implied consent information. To encourage participation and maximize the response rate, three outreach attempts were made: an initial invitation on April 14, 2025, followed by reminders on April 21 and April 28, 2025. The survey closed on May 2, 2025, at 11:59 p.m. A total of 264 responses were received. Of these, 5 indicated that the respondents did not meet the study's eligibility criteria, and 24 responses, though from eligible participants, were incomplete. After these exclusions, 235 complete and eligible responses remained. This represented a response rate of approximately 13.48%, based on a contact list of 1,743 eligible institutions. However, the actual rate may be higher, as the list did not account for centralized financial aid offices that may serve multiple institutions or campus locations.

Data Analysis

Once the data was collected, it was analyzed using statistical techniques aligned with each research question. A summary of the statistical techniques employed in this study is provided in Table 1. In addition to the analyses detailed in the table, participant demographic data was compiled and presented using descriptive statistics. Frequencies and percentages were reported for variables including years of experience, institutional type, institutional size, institutional region, staff size, gender identity, race/ethnicity, and age.

Table 1

Data Analysis Strategies for Research Questions

Research Question	Source of Data	Statistical Technique
1. How do financial aid leaders perceive the importance of professional competencies to success in their role?	Survey Responses – Mean Scores of Competency Areas	Descriptive Statistics; Means and Standard Deviations
2. How do financial aid leaders' perception of professional competencies differ as a function of: • Years of Experience • Institutional Type • Institutional Size • Institutional Region • Staff Size • Gender Identity • Race/Ethnicity • Age	Survey Responses – Demographic Variables; Mean Scores of Competency Areas	Inferential Statistics; One-Way Analysis of Variance (ANOVA): • Years of Experience • Institutional Size • Institutional Region • Staff Size • Age Independent Samples *t* test: • Institutional Type • Gender Identity • Race/Ethnicity
3. How are professional competencies for effective practice as a financial aid leader developed?	Survey Responses – Competency Development Methods and Resources	Descriptive Statistics; Frequencies and Percentages

For research questions 1 and 3, descriptive statistics were employed to organize and summarize the characteristics of the data, providing an overview of general trends and patterns (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019; Salkind & Frey, 2020). For question 1, the mean score was calculated for each of the six competency areas to represent the central tendency of responses, while the standard deviation was reported to capture the variability among individual responses. For question 3, frequencies and percentages were calculated to describe the methods and resources financial aid leaders used to develop competencies across the six focus areas.

For research question 2, inferential statistics were employed to examine the mean scores of financial aid leaders based on years of experience, institutional type, institutional size, institutional region, staff size, gender identity, race/ethnicity, and age. Specifically, independent

samples *t* tests and one-way analysis of variance (ANOVA) tests were conducted to assess differences between groups and determine whether observed differences were statistically significant. Both tests are appropriate for analyzing differences in group means for quantitative data; the independent samples *t* test was used when the independent variable had two categories, while one-way ANOVA was applied when the independent variable included more than two categories (Mertler & Vannatta Reinhart, 2017; Salkind & Frey, 2020). Prior to conducting analyses, the data was cleaned and prepared, and statistical assumptions were evaluated.

Addressing outliers—cases with extreme values at one or both ends of a sample distribution—was essential, as they can distort the results of statistical analyses (Mertler & Vannatta Reinhart, 2017). Outliers in the dataset were identified through visual inspection of histograms, Q-Q plots, and box plots, and were dropped from the specific analyses. Additionally, it was essential to confirm that the data met the underlying assumptions associated with the statistical tests used in this study to ensure the validity and reliability of the results. For both independent samples *t* tests and one-way ANOVA, the key assumptions include independence of observations, normality, and homogeneity of variance.

The first assumption, independence of observations, requires that each observation reflects a unique, unrelated unit (Field, 2018). In this study, the assumption was addressed through several aspects of the research design. Specifically, independence was maintained by collecting only one response per participant, with purposive sampling ensuring that each financial aid leader represented only their respective institution (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019; Ponto, 2015). Although some institutions belonged to larger multi-campus systems with centralized financial aid offices, the researcher utilized IP address tracking to limit submissions to only one response per financial aid leader. This approach effectively prevented multiple

observations from the same respondent, ensuring that each data point was independent. The online, individually administered nature of the survey additionally minimized the likelihood of peer influence between participants (Ponto, 2015).

The second assumption, normality, requires that the dependent variable be approximately normally distributed within each group of the independent variable (Mertler & Vannatta Reinhart, 2017). To assess this assumption, histograms and Q-Q plots were examined for all combinations of dependent and independent variables. Based on these visual inspections, the assumption of normality was determined to be satisfactorily met across all relevant groups.

The third assumption, homogeneity of variance, refers to the requirement that the variances of the dependent variable be approximately equal across the groups or categories of the independent variable (Mertler & Vannatta Reinhart, 2017; Salkind & Frey, 2020). Levene's test was employed to assess this assumption. When Levene's test yielded a non-statistically significant result ($p > 0.05$), the assumption of homogeneity of variance was considered met. However, in cases where Levene's test produced a statistically significant result ($p < 0.05$), indicating that the assumption had been violated, alternative statistical procedures were applied. Specifically, when independent samples *t* tests failed to meet this assumption, the unequal variance *t* test was used, consistent with Ruxton's (2006) recommendation that this approach is preferable to alternatives such as the Mann–Whitney *U* test. When one-way ANOVA analyses showed unequal variances, Welch's ANOVA was used (Myers et al., 2010).

For this research, all analyses were conducted using a significance level (alpha) of 0.05, one of the most used thresholds in behavioral science research (Mertler & Vannatta Reinhart, 2017). To complement significance testing, effect sizes were reported to assess the practical significance of the findings. Effect sizes quantify the strength of the difference between two

means or variables, offering insight into their real-world relevance (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019; Salkind & Frey, 2020). For analyses where the independent variable had two categories, Cohen's *d* was used, with benchmarks of 0.20 for a small effect, 0.50 for a medium effect, and 0.80 for a large effect (Cohen, 1988). Eta-squared (η^2) was reported when the independent variable included more than two categories, using Cohen's (1988) benchmarks of 0.01 for a small effect, 0.06 for a medium effect, and 0.14 for a large effect.

Research Question 1

For Research Question 1, which investigated how financial aid leaders perceive the importance of professional competencies to success in their role, descriptive statistics served as the foundation for summarizing and presenting the survey data. Specifically, mean scores were calculated for each competency area to identify the average perceived importance, while standard deviations provided insight into the level of agreement among respondents. This analysis enabled identification of the competency areas most valued by financial aid leaders.

Research Question 2

To address Research Question 2—whether perceptions of professional competencies differed based on demographic and institutional characteristics—a combination of inferential statistical tests were conducted to compare mean competency scores based on the variables outlined in Table 2.

Table 2

Variable List for Research Question Two

Independent Variable	Dependent Variable
Years of Experience	Mean Scores of Competency Areas from Survey
Institutional Type	Mean Scores of Competency Areas from Survey
Institutional Size	Mean Scores of Competency Areas from Survey
Institutional Region	Mean Scores of Competency Areas from Survey
Staff Size	Mean Scores of Competency Areas from Survey
Gender Identity	Mean Scores of Competency Areas from Survey
Race/Ethnicity	Mean Scores of Competency Areas from Survey
Age	Mean Scores of Competency Areas from Survey

One-way ANOVA tests examined years of experience, institutional size, institutional region, staff size, and age. Due to distribution of responses, certain demographic variables required adjustment. For institutional type, responses were consolidated into two categories: two-year institutions and four-year institutions (with “Public 4-Year Only” and “Public 4-Year & Above” combined). For gender identity, only responses identifying as "man" or "woman" were included; responses of "non-binary" and "prefer not to respond" were excluded. Lastly, race/ethnicity was categorized as White and non-White, with all specified non-White identities grouped together and “prefer not to respond” responses excluded. Because these three variables involved only two groups, independent samples *t* tests were conducted—a method commonly used to assess whether mean differences between two independent groups are statistically significant (Ross & Willson, 2017).

The use of both one-way ANOVA and *t* tests provided a comprehensive analysis of whether perceptions of professional competency areas varied meaningfully across demographic and institutional characteristics. While one-way ANOVA identifies whether there are statistically significant differences among group means, it does not indicate which specific group pairs differ (Gaciu, 2021; Holcomb & Cox, 2018). To determine these pairwise differences, this study

employed post hoc tests, including Tukey's and Duncan's.

Research Question 3

Research Question 3 focused on how professional competencies are developed by financial aid leaders. This analysis relied on descriptive statistics, specifically frequencies and percentages, to summarize the methods and resources identified by participants as helpful in their professional development. This approach highlighted the most common strategies used by financial aid leaders for growth within each focus area.

Biases

It is essential to acknowledge potential biases when conducting research. The researcher's professional background, which includes over 10 years of experience in higher education—spanning roles as a Federal Work-Study student, graduate assistant, and full-time employee—and more than 4 years in the financial aid sector, provided familiarity with the roles and responsibilities of higher education professionals and financial aid leaders. While this background offered valuable insight, it is important to note that one of the strengths of using a quantitative research design is the ability to minimize the influence of personal experience on the study's findings. In this quantitative study, the use of objective survey data and statistical analyses helped ensure impartiality, limiting the potential for researcher bias affecting the results. However, it is crucial to acknowledge both actual and perceived biases in the research process to maintain transparency and ensure the integrity of the study. Despite the objective nature of the methodology, the researcher's experiences may have influenced the formulation of research questions or interpretations of the data, particularly in understanding why particular competencies were ranked in certain ways or why certain group differences emerged.

Ethical Considerations

Ethical considerations are paramount in conducting research, particularly with respect to safeguarding participant confidentiality, minimizing risks associated with participation, and respecting the rights of respondents (Creswell & Guetterman, 2019). To this end, data collected from participants was stored securely and managed in accordance with relevant Institutional Review Board (IRB) guidelines. All participant information remained confidential, and no identifying details were collected. Specifically, the survey did not ask for participant names, contact information, or institutional affiliation. The data gathered included eligibility screening responses; participants' rankings of competencies; participants' selections on methods and resources for professional development; and contextual information including years of experience, institutional type, institutional size, institutional region, staff size, gender identity, race/ethnicity, and age. Prior to participation, all individuals were provided with implied consent information within the outreach email received, outlining the study's purpose and any potential risks associated with their involvement. This ensured participants were fully aware of their rights and the voluntary nature of their participation. Additionally, the researcher completed the required Collaborative Institutional Training Initiative (CITI) training modules, in accordance with institutional ethical standards and best practices for human subject research.

Summary

This chapter provided a comprehensive overview of the methodological approach utilized in this study. The researcher chose a quantitative research methodology, with an electronic survey serving as the primary data collection instrument. The chapter also discussed several key aspects of the research design, including the rationale for the chosen methodology, potential researcher biases, and ethical considerations. Additionally, the chapter detailed the participant

selection process, including the use of purposive sampling to target financial aid leaders at public colleges and universities across the United States. Furthermore, data collection and analysis processes were outlined, emphasizing how descriptive and inferential statistics aided in the presentation and interpretation of the data. The findings from this study deepen understanding of the competencies most valued by financial aid leaders. By identifying the skills, knowledge, and behaviors necessary for success, this study aimed to contribute to scholarly literature on financial aid administration and offer practical recommendations for improving practice in the field.

CHAPTER IV

FINDINGS

This chapter presents the results of this quantitative study conducted to examine financial aid leaders' perceptions of professional competencies and how those competencies are developed. Findings are organized around the study's three primary research questions:

1. How do financial aid leaders perceive the importance of professional competencies to success in their role?
2. How do financial aid leaders' perceptions of professional competencies differ as a function of:
    - Years of Experience
    - Institutional Type
    - Institutional Size
    - Institutional Region
    - Staff Size
    - Gender Identity
    - Race/Ethnicity
    - Age
3. How are professional competencies for effective practice as a financial aid leader developed?

The research questions explored in this study were shaped by gaps identified in the literature and grounded in a skills-based leadership framework. As discussed in previous chapters, financial aid leaders operate in increasingly complex and regulated environments and are tasked with responsibilities that include compliance, strategic planning, personnel oversight, and student

support. Each section of this chapter introduces one of the three research questions, accompanied by a brief rationale to reinforce its relevance to the broader context of higher education leadership and financial aid practice. Descriptive statistics, inferential analyses, and tables are used to present the results. The findings are presented objectively, without interpretation, to preserve the analytic focus of this chapter. Interpretation and discussion of the results are reserved for Chapter 5. The chapter begins with a summary of participant characteristics to provide context for the analyses.

Participant Characteristics

A total of 235 financial aid leaders from public colleges and universities across the United States participated in this study. Table 3 presents the frequency and percentage distributions of the participant characteristics, including years of experience, institutional type, institutional size, institutional region, staff size, gender identity, race/ethnicity, and age.

Table 3

Participant Characteristics Response Distribution

	N	*%*
Years of Experience	**235**	**100.0%**
Less than 1 Year	8	3.4%
1-5 Years	53	22.6%
6-10 Years	42	17.9%
11-15 Years	43	18.3%
16-20 Years	24	10.2%
20+ Years	65	27.7%
Institutional Type	**235**	**100.0%**
Public 2-Year	119	50.6%
Public 4-Year Only	25	10.6%
Public 4-Year & Above	91	38.7%
Institutional Size	**235**	**100.0%**
Fewer than 500 full-time equivalent (FTE) students	2	0.9%
500-1,999 FTE students	30	12.8%
2,000-4,999 FTE students	56	23.8%
5,000-9,999 FTE students	63	26.8%
10,000+ FTE students	84	35.7%

Institutional Region	**235**	**100.0%**
Eastern	46	19.6%
Midwest	47	20.0%
Rocky Mountain	15	6.4%
Southern	51	21.7%
Southwest	33	14.0%
Western	43	18.3%
Staff Size	**235**	**100.0%**
1-5	53	22.6%
6-10	84	35.7%
11-15	41	17.4%
16-20	14	6.0%
21+	43	18.3%
Gender Identity	**235**	**100.0%**
Man	68	28.9%
Woman	160	68.1%
Non-Binary	2	0.9%
Prefer not to respond	5	2.1%
Race/Ethnicity	**235**	**100.0%**
American Indian or Alaskan Native	3	1.3%
Asian / Pacific Islander	4	1.7%
Black or African American	23	9.8%
Hispanic	20	8.5%
White / Caucasian	176	74.9%
Race/Ethnicity Not Listed	3	1.3%
Prefer not to respond	6	2.6%
Age	**235**	**100.0%**
18 to 24	0	0.00%
25 to 34	12	5.1%
35 to 44	64	27.2%
45 to 54	88	37.4%
55 to 64	60	25.5%
65 and over	11	4.7%

Participants reported a broad range of years of experience as a financial aid leader. The largest subgroup (*N* = 65, 27.7%) reported more than 20 years of experience. Other notable groups included those with 1–5 years (*N* = 53, 22.6%), 11–15 years (*N* = 43, 18.3%), and 6-10 years (*N* = 42, 17.9%) of experience. Smaller proportions reported 16–20 years (*N* = 24, 10.2%), and less than one year (*N* = 8, 3.4%). About half of respondents (*N* = 119, 50.6%) were affiliated with public two-year institutions. Among those at four-year institutions, 10.6% (*N* = 25) served

at public four-year only institutions and 38.7% (*N* = 91) at public four-year and above institutions, yielding a combined total of 49.3% (*N* = 116) from four-year institutions overall.

Respondents represented institutions of varied sizes based on full-time equivalent (FTE) student enrollment. The most common group (*N* = 84, 35.7%) reported serving at institutions with 10,000 or more FTE students. Other groups included institutions with 5,000–9,999 FTE (*N* = 63, 26.8%), 2,000–4,999 FTE (*N* = 56, 23.8%), and 500–1,999 FTE (*N* = 30, 12.8%). Only 0.9% (*N* = 2) were from institutions with fewer than 500 FTE students. Participants represented all major geographic regions of the U.S. The highest concentration was in the Southern region (*N* = 51, 21.7%), followed by the Midwest (*N* = 47, 20.0%) and Eastern (*N* = 46, 19.6%) regions. The Western region accounted for 18.3% (*N* = 43), the Southwest for 14.0% (*N* = 33), and the Rocky Mountain region for 6.4% (*N* = 15). In terms of staff size, the most frequently reported group (*N* = 84, 35.7%) worked in a financial aid office with 6–10 staff members. Additional groups included offices with 1–5 staff (*N* = 53, 22.6%), 11–15 staff (*N* = 41, 17.4%), 21 or more staff (*N* = 43, 18.3%), and 16–20 staff (*N* = 14, 6.0%).

Most respondents identified as women (*N* = 160, 68.1%), followed by men (*N* = 68, 28.9%). A small number identified as non-binary (*N* = 2, 0.9%) or selected "prefer not to respond" (*N* = 5, 2.1%). The sample was predominantly White/Caucasian (*N* = 176, 74.9%). Other racial/ethnic groups included Black or African American (*N* = 23, 9.8%), Hispanic (*N* = 20, 8.5%), Asian/Pacific Islander (*N* = 4, 1.7%), and American Indian or Alaskan Native (*N* = 3, 1.3%). A small portion identified with a race/ethnicity not listed (*N* = 3, 1.3%) or selected "prefer not to respond" (*N* = 6, 2.6%). Participants ranged in age from 25 to over 65 years; no participants reported being under the age of 25. The largest age group was 45–54 years (*N* = 88,

37.4%), followed by 35–44 years (*N* = 64, 27.2%) and 55–64 years (*N* = 60, 25.5%). Smaller proportions included those aged 25–34 (*N* = 12, 5.1%) and 65 or older (*N* = 11, 4.7%).

Research Question 1

The first research question guiding this study was: "How do financial aid leaders perceive the importance of professional competencies to success in their role?" Chapter II outlined multiple competency models across higher education and emphasized the need for leadership-specific frameworks in financial aid. Research Question 1 addresses this gap by identifying which of the six key competency areas are perceived as most important by financial aid leaders. As described in earlier chapters, financial aid leaders must balance an array of responsibilities, often with limited resources and staffing. Identifying which competencies are prioritized by those serving in financial aid leadership roles provides a foundation for understanding how skills align with the expectations and complexities highlighted in the literature review and offers insight to inform targeted professional development and leadership preparation efforts.

Table 4 presents the mean scores and standard deviations for the six competency areas explored through this research—*Laws and Regulations*, *Career Development*, *Leadership Skills*, *Customer Service*, *Technical Proficiency*, and *Business of Education*.

Table 4

Mean Scores of Competency Areas

Competency Area	***N***	***M***	***SD***
Laws & Regulations	235	3.60	0.337
Career Development	235	3.73	0.365
Leadership Skills	235	3.60	0.312
Customer Service	235	3.56	0.331
Technical Proficiency	235	3.65	0.408
Business of Education	235	3.35	0.450

Among the six major competency areas, *Career Development* emerged with the highest overall mean score (*M* = 3.73, *SD* = 0.365), indicating that financial aid leaders place particularly strong value on competencies related to professional growth, collaboration, teamwork, and developing skills for themselves and others. Close behind, *Technical Proficiency* (*M* = 3.65, *SD* = 0.408) was also rated highly, reflecting the importance of digital communication, electronic processing, and leveraging technology to improve efficiency. *Laws and Regulations* (*M* = 3.60, *SD* = 0.337) and *Leadership Skills* (*M* = 3.60, *SD* = 0.312) were tied in overall ratings, emphasizing the perceived importance of both compliance-related knowledge, including financial aid legislative expertise and Title IV requirements, and leadership competencies such as strategic thinking, problem solving, decision making, and critical thinking. *Customer Service* (*M* = 3.56, *SD* = 0.331) followed, reflecting the value placed on communication, advising, empathy, cultural competence, and respect in financial aid leadership roles. Finally, *Business of Education* (*M* = 3.35, *SD* = 0.450) ranked lowest among the six areas, suggesting that while still relevant, competencies such as institutional context, interdepartmental practices, risk assessment, and models of governance and accreditation were viewed as comparatively less critical to the day-to-day responsibilities of financial aid leaders. While these findings address overall perceptions of competency importance, the subsequent section explores whether perceptions differ across demographic and institutional subgroups.

Research Question 2

The second research question examined whether perceptions of professional competencies differ according to selected individual and institutional variables. This inquiry recognizes that leaders' views may be shaped by their institutional environment, professional background, or demographic identity. Exploring these differences enhances understanding of

how competencies are contextualized across various settings and can inform the design of more responsive, inclusive, and effective training and development initiatives.

To investigate, a combination of independent samples *t* tests and one-way ANOVA was employed. For variables with two groups, including institutional type (collapsed into two-year and four-year), gender identity (limited to "man" and "woman"), and race/ethnicity (categorized as White and non-White, excluding “prefer not to respond”), independent samples *t* tests were conducted. One-way ANOVA was used for variables with more than two groups, including years of experience, institutional size, institutional region, staff size, and age. Findings are presented in Tables 5 through 12 and detailed in the following sections.

Years of Experience

To examine whether financial aid leaders’ perceptions of professional competencies differ based on years of experience, six one-way ANOVAs were conducted. The results are presented in Table 5. The assumption of homogeneity of variance was violated for the *Technical Proficiency* competency area ($p < 0.05$); therefore, Welch’s ANOVA was used for this analysis. Post hoc tests were conducted when the one-way ANOVA results indicated statistically significant differences to identify specific group differences. Overall, a statistically significant difference was found for one competency area, *Business of Education*, based on years of experience. Thus, the null hypothesis was rejected.

Table 5

Summary of One-Way ANOVA of Financial Aid Leaders' Perception of Professional Competencies as a Function of Years of Experience

Variables and Source	*df*	*SS*	*MS*	*F*	*p*
Laws & Regulations					
Between Groups	5	0.492	0.098	1.236	0.293
Within Groups	218	17.349	0.80		
Career Development					
Between Groups	5	0.281	0.056	0.519	0.762
Within Groups	228	24.692	0.108		
Leadership Skills					
Between Groups	5	0.896	0.179	2.072	0.070
Within Groups	227	19.647	0.087		
Customer Service					
Between Groups	5	0.635	0.127	1.252	0.286
Within Groups	227	23.037	0.101		
Technical Proficiency[a]					
Between Groups	5	1.439	0.288	1.454	0.221
Within Groups	52	37.604	0.164		
Business of Education					
Between Groups	5	2.424	0.485	3.021	0.012*
Within Groups	226	36.272	0.160		

Note. [a] = Welch's ANOVA utilized, * = p < .05.

To better understand these results, the mean scores and significance levels for each competency area are examined in detail, beginning with *Laws and Regulations*. The mean scores for *Laws and Regulations* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders with less than 1 year (M = 3.64, SD = 0.244), 1-5 years (M = 3.65, SD = 0.292), 6-10 years (M = 3.61, SD = 0.277), 11-15 years (M = 3.65, SD = 0.302), 16-20 years (M = 3.52, SD = 0.291), and 20+ (M = 3.68, SD = 0.264) years of experience, $F(5,218) = 1.236$, p = 0.293. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test (p = 0.906).

Following *Laws and Regulations*, the next area explored was *Career Development*. The mean scores for *Career Development* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders with less than 1 year (M = 3.63, SD = 0.354), 1-5 (M = 3.78, SD =

0.309), 6-10 (M = 3.76, SD = 0.356), 11-15 (M = 3.71, SD = 0.344), 16-20 (M = 3.70, SD = 0.346), and 20+ (M = 3.75, SD = 0.308) years of experience, $F(5,228) = 0.519$, $p = 0.762$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test (p = 0.736).

The third competency area analyzed was *Leadership Skills*, which approached but did not reach statistical significance. The mean scores for *Leadership Skills* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders with less than 1 year (M = 3.38, SD = 0.406), 1-5 (M = 3.64, SD = 0.290), 6-10 (M = 3.64, SD = 0.272), 11-15 (M = 3.61, SD = 0.302), 16-20 (M = 3.50, SD = 0.269), and 20+ (M = 3.64, SD = 0.300) years of experience, $F(5,227) = 2.072$, $p = 0.070$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test (p = 0.401).

Customer Service was then evaluated to determine any variation across experience levels. The mean scores for *Customer Service* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders with less than 1 year (M = 3.44, SD = 0.230), 1-5 (M = 3.60, SD = 0.340), 6-10 (M = 3.64, SD = 0.282), 11-15 (M = 3.56, SD = 0.286), 16-20 (M = 3.47, SD = 0.421), and 20+ (M = 3.54, SD = 0.310) years of experience, $F(5,227) = 1.252$, $p = 0.286$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test (p = 0.126).

Technical Proficiency presented unique statistical considerations due to unequal variances, necessitating a different analytical approach. The mean scores for *Technical Proficiency* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders with less than 1 year (M = 3.58, SD = 0.496), 1-5 (M = 3.68, SD = 0.428), 6-10 (M = 3.67, SD = 0.312), 11-15 (M = 3.57, SD = 0.450), 16-20 (M = 3.49, SD = 0.481), and 20+ (M = 3.73, SD =

0.364) years of experience, Welch's $F(5,52) = 1.454$, $p = 0.221$. The variances were not assumed to be equal based on the significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.023$); thus, Welch's ANOVA was utilized.

Unlike the other competency areas, *Business of Education* revealed a statistically significant difference, warranting closer examination of group differences. The mean scores for *Business of Education* did demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders with less than 1 year ($M = 3.22$, $SD = 0.479$), 1-5 ($M = 3.47$, $SD = 0.418$), 6-10 ($M = 3.47$, $SD = 0.376$), 11-15 ($M = 3.35$, $SD = 0.451$), 16-20 ($M = 3.13$, $SD = 0.307$), and 20+ ($M = 3.36$, $SD = 0.389$) years of experience, $F(5,226) = 3.021$, $p = 0.012$, $\eta^2 = 0.06$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.126$). Eta-squared indicated a medium effect size ($\eta^2 = 0.06$). Tukey's post hoc test was conducted, which revealed that financial aid leaders with 1-5 years of experience ($M = 3.47$, $SD = 0.418$) reported mean scores statistically significantly higher ($p = 0.012$) than financial aid leaders with 16-20 years of experience ($M = 3.13$, $SD = 0.307$), and financial aid leaders with 6-10 years of experience ($M = 3.47$, $SD = 0.376$) reported mean scores statistically significantly higher ($p = 0.015$) than financial aid leaders with 16-20 years of experience ($M = 3.13$, $SD = 0.307$), in relation to *Business of Education* competencies.

Institutional Type

To examine how financial aid leaders' perceptions of professional competencies differ as a function of institutional type, six independent samples *t* tests were conducted. Given the distribution of responses, institutional type was consolidated into two categories: two-year institutions and four-year institutions. Approximately half of respondents ($N = 119$, 50.6%) were affiliated with public two-year institutions. Among those affiliated with four-year institutions,

10.6% (*N* = 25) identified as serving at public four-year only institutions, while 38.7% (*N* = 91) reported serving at public four-year and above institutions. Due to the relatively small size of the "Public 4-Year Only" group and its conceptual similarity to the "Public 4-year & Above" group, these two categories were combined to create a single "4-year institutions" category (*N* = 116, 49.3%) to allow for a more meaningful and statistically reliable comparison. The results of the tests are presented in Table 6. Overall, a statistically significant difference was indicated between financial aid leaders at two-year institutions and four-year institutions for five competency areas (*Laws and Regulations, Career Development*, *Customer Service*, *Technical Proficiency*, and *Business of Education*). Thus, the null hypothesis was rejected.

Table 6

Summary of Independent Samples t test of Financial Aid Leaders' Perception of Professional Competencies as a Function of Institutional Type

	2-Year Institution			**4-Year Institution**						
Variable	***N***	***M***	***SD***	***N***	***M***	***SD***	***df***	***t***	***p***	***d***
Laws & Regulations	113	3.68	0.283	111	3.60	0.278	222	2.137	0.034*	0.29
Career Development	119	3.79	0.304	115	3.69	0.345	232	2.224	0.027*	0.29
Leadership Skills	118	3.64	0.294	115	3.58	0.298	231	1.740	0.083	0.23
Customer Service	119	3.61	0.310	114	3.52	0.324	231	2.080	0.039*	0.27
Technical Proficiency	119	3.72	0.383	116	3.58	0.422	233	2.706	0.007*	0.35
Business of Education	118	3.44	0.422	114	3.31	0.387	230	2.367	0.019*	0.31

Note. * = p < .05.

Starting with the *Laws and Regulations* competency area, the analysis revealed differences between institutional types. The mean scores for *Laws and Regulations* showed a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders at two-year institutions (*M* = 3.68, *SD* = 0.283) and those at four-year institutions (*M* = 3.60, *SD* = 0.278), $t(222) = 2.137$, $p = 0.034$, $d = 0.29$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.853$). Cohen's *d* indicated a small effect size ($d = 0.29$).

Turning to *Career Development*, a similar pattern emerged with a significant difference observed between the two groups. The mean scores for *Career Development* showed a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders at two-year institutions (M = 3.79, SD = 0.304) and those at four-year institutions (M = 3.69, SD = 0.345), $t(232) = 2.224$, p = 0.027, d = 0.29. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test (p = 0.125). Cohen's d indicated a small effect size (d = 0.29).

In contrast, the *Leadership Skills* competency area did not show a statistically significant difference based on institutional type. The mean scores for *Leadership Skills* did not differ significantly between financial aid leaders at two-year institutions (M = 3.64, SD = 0.294) and those at four-year institutions (M = 3.58, SD = 0.298), $t(231) = 1.740$, p = 0.083, d = 0.23. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test (p = 0.681).

Returning to competencies with significant differences, the *Customer Service* area also showed a notable distinction between institutional types. The mean scores for *Customer Service* showed a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders at two-year institutions (M = 3.61, SD = 0.310) and those at four-year institutions (M = 3.52, SD = 0.324), $t(231)$ = 2.080, p = 0.039, d = 0.27. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test (p = 0.557). Cohen's d indicated a small effect size (d = 0.27).

Technical Proficiency likewise demonstrated a significant gap between financial aid leaders serving at different institutional types. The mean scores for *Technical Proficiency* showed a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders at two-year institutions (M = 3.72, SD = 0.383) and those at four-year institutions (M = 3.58, SD = 0.422), $t(233)$ =

2.706, $p = 0.007$, $d = 0.35$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.113$). Cohen's d indicated a small-to-medium effect size ($d = 0.35$).

Finally, the *Business of Education* competency showed a significant difference, rounding out the areas where institutional type played a meaningful role. The mean scores for *Business of Education* showed a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders at two-year institutions ($M = 3.44$, $SD = 0.422$) and those at four-year institutions ($M = 3.31$, $SD = 0.387$), $t(230) = 2.367$, $p = 0.019$, $d = 0.31$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.320$). Cohen's d indicated a small effect size ($d = 0.31$).

Overall, financial aid leaders serving at different institutional types consistently reported mean scores with statistically significant differences. The competency areas that exhibited a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders at two-year institutions and four-year institutions were *Laws and Regulations, Career Development*, *Customer Service*, *Technical Proficiency*, and *Business of Education*. In all five cases, financial aid leaders serving at two-year institutions reported higher mean scores than those at four-year institutions.

Institutional Size

To examine whether financial aid leaders' perceptions of professional competencies differ based on institutional size, six one-way ANOVAs were conducted. The results are presented in Table 7. Overall, there were no statistically significant differences found based on institutional size. Thus, the null hypothesis was accepted.

Table 7

Summary of One-Way ANOVA of Financial Aid Leaders' Perception of Professional Competencies as a Function of Institutional Size

Variables and Source	***df***	***SS***	***MS***	***F***	***p***
Laws & Regulations					
Between Groups	4	0.196	0.049	0.608	0.657
Within Groups	219	17.645	0.081		
Career Development					
Between Groups	4	0.189	0.047	0.436	0.783
Within Groups	229	24.785	0.108		
Leadership Skills					
Between Groups	4	0.376	0.094	1.062	0.376
Within Groups	228	20.167	0.088		
Customer Service					
Between Groups	4	0.216	0.054	0.524	0.718
Within Groups	228	23.457	0.103		
Technical Proficiency					
Between Groups	4	0.437	0.109	0.651	0.627
Within Groups	230	38.606	0.168		
Business of Education					
Between Groups	4	0.820	0.205	1.228	0.300
Within Groups	227	37.876	0.167		

Beginning with *Laws and Regulations*, the analysis showed no statistically significant differences across institutional sizes. The mean scores for *Laws and Regulations* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions with fewer than 500 full-time equivalent (FTE) students (M = 3.38, SD = 0.177), 500-1,999 FTE students (M = 3.64, SD = 0.336), 2,000-4,999 FTE students (M = 3.66, SD = 0.259), 5,000-9,999 FTE students (M = 3.62, SD = 0.293), and 10,000+ FTE students (M = 3.64, SD = 0.274), $F(5,219) = 0.608$, $p = 0.657$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.216$).

Similarly, the *Career Development* competency area did not reveal any statistically significant differences among the institutional size groups. The mean scores for *Career*

Development did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions with fewer than 500 full-time equivalent (FTE) students (M = 3.75, SD = 0.354), 500-1,999 FTE students (M = 3.67, SD = 0.385), 2,000-4,999 FTE students (M = 3.75, SD = 0.327), 5,000-9,999 FTE students (M = 3.76, SD = 0.324), and 10,000+ FTE students (M = 3.74, SD = 0.312), $F(4,229) = 0.436$, $p = 0.783$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.305$).

The *Leadership Skills* competency area also demonstrated no statistically significant variation based on institutional size. The mean scores for *Leadership Skills* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions with fewer than 500 full-time equivalent (FTE) students (M = 3.50, SD = 0.141), 500-1,999 FTE students (M = 3.56, SD = 0.321), 2,000-4,999 FTE students (M = 3.63, SD = 0.304), 5,000-9,999 FTE students (M = 3.57, SD = 0.304), and 10,000+ FTE students (M = 3.65, SD = 0.279), $F(4,228) = 1.062$, $p = 0.376$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.547$).

Consistent with the previous results, the *Customer Service* competency area showed no statistically significant differences among the size categories. The mean scores for *Customer Service* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions with fewer than 500 full-time equivalent (FTE) students (M = 3.78, SD = 0.157), 500-1,999 FTE students (M = 3.52, SD = 0.285), 2,000-4,999 FTE students (M = 3.59, SD = 0.294), 5,000-9,999 FTE students (M = 3.54, SD = 0.348), and 10,000+ FTE students (M = 3.57, SD = 0.330), $F(4,228) = 0.524$, $p = 0.718$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.512$).

Technical Proficiency followed the same pattern, with no statistically significant differences detected across institutions of varying sizes. The mean scores for *Technical Proficiency* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions with fewer than 500 full-time equivalent (FTE) students ($M = 3.83$, $SD = 0.236$), 500-1,999 FTE students ($M = 3.63$, $SD = 0.423$), 2,000-4,999 FTE students ($M = 3.71$, $SD = 0.392$), 5,000-9,999 FTE students ($M = 3.60$, $SD = 0.420$), and 10,000+ FTE students ($M = 3.65$, $SD = 0.410$), $F(4,230) = 0.651$, $p = 0.627$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.503$).

Lastly, the *Business of Education* competency area did not exhibit any statistically significant differences as a function of institutional size. The mean scores for *Business of Education* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions with fewer than 500 full-time equivalent (FTE) students ($M = 3.28$, $SD = 0.393$), 500-1,999 FTE students ($M = 3.31$, $SD = 0.464$), 2,000-4,999 FTE students ($M = 3.45$, $SD = 0.370$), 5,000-9,999 FTE students ($M = 3.31$, $SD = 0.403$), and 10,000+ FTE students ($M = 3.40$, $SD = 0.416$), $F(4,227) = 1.228$, $p = 0.300$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.365$).

Institutional Region

To examine whether financial aid leaders' perceptions of professional competencies differ based on institutional region, six one-way ANOVAs were conducted. The results are presented in Table 8. The assumption of homogeneity of variance was violated for the *Career Development* competency area ($p < 0.05$); therefore, Welch's ANOVA was used for this analysis. Overall, there were no statistically significant differences found based on institutional region. Thus, the null hypothesis was accepted.

Table 8

Summary of One-Way ANOVA of Financial Aid Leaders' Perception of Professional Competencies as a Function of Institutional Region

Variables and Source	*df*	*SS*	*MS*	*F*	*p*
Laws & Regulations					
Between Groups	5	0.465	0.093	1.168	0.326
Within Groups	218	17.376	0.080		
Career Development[a]					
Between Groups	5	0.750	0.150	2.309	0.051
Within Groups	87	24.223	0.106		
Leadership Skills					
Between Groups	5	0.382	0.076	0.859	0.509
Within Groups	227	20.162	0.089		
Customer Service					
Between Groups	5	0.366	0.073	0.713	0.614
Within Groups	227	23.306	0.103		
Technical Proficiency					
Between Groups	5	1.495	0.299	1.823	0.109
Within Groups	229	37.548	0.164		
Business of Education					
Between Groups	5	1.502	0.300	1.825	0.109
Within Groups	226	37.194	0.165		

Note. [a] = Welch's ANOVA utilized

Starting with *Laws and Regulations*, the analysis revealed no statistically significant differences across institutional regions. The mean scores for *Laws and Regulations* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions in the Eastern (M = 3.61, SD = 0.294), Midwest (M = 3.61, SD = 0.287), Rocky Mountain (M = 3.50, SD = 0.277), Southern (M = 3.67, SD = 0.268), Southwest (M = 3.68, SD = 0.247), and Western (M = 3.67, SD = 0.303) regions, $F(5,218) = 1.168$, $p = 0.326$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.587$).

Turning to *Career Development*, the results similarly showed no statistically significant differences among regions, even after accounting for unequal variances using Welch's ANOVA. The mean scores for *Career Development* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions in the Eastern (M = 3.72, SD =

0.358), Midwest (M = 3.69, SD = 0.373), Rocky Mountain (M = 3.60, SD = 0.207), Southern (M = 3.75, SD = 0.318), Southwest (M = 3.83, SD = 0.277), and Western (M = 3.77, SD = 0.311) regions, Welch's $F(5,87) = 2.309$, $p = 0.051$. The variances were not assumed to be equal based on the significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.037$); thus, Welch's ANOVA was utilized.

The *Leadership Skills* competency area also demonstrated no statistically significant variation across the different institutional regions. The mean scores for *Leadership Skills* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions in the Eastern (M = 3.62, SD = 0.297), Midwest (M = 3.59, SD = 0.306), Rocky Mountain (M = 3.48, SD = 0.246), Southern (M = 3.63, SD = 0.297), Southwest (M = 3.66, SD = 0.315), and Western (M = 3.61, SD = 0.294) regions, $F(5,227) = 0.859$, $p = 0.509$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.674$).

In line with the previous findings, *Customer Service* showed no statistically significant differences based on institutional region. The mean scores for *Customer Service* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions in the Eastern (M = 3.60, SD = 0.307), Midwest (M = 3.58, SD = 0.350), Rocky Mountain (M = 3.44, SD = 0.297), Southern (M = 3.58, SD = 0.304), Southwest (M = 3.57, SD = 0.333), and Western (M = 3.53, SD = 0.317) regions, $F(5,227) = 0.713$, $p = 0.614$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.972$).

The pattern continued with *Technical Proficiency*, where no meaningful regional differences were detected. The mean scores for *Technical Proficiency* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions in the Eastern (M = 3.65, SD = 0.385), Midwest (M = 3.60, SD = 0.403), Rocky Mountain (M = 3.40, SD = 0.491), Southern (M = 3.71, SD = 0.395), Southwest (M = 3.74, SD = 0.389), and Western

(M = 3.64, SD = 0.420) regions, $F(5,229) = 1.823$, $p = 0.109$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.534$).

Finally, the *Business of Education* competency area did not exhibit any statistically significant differences as a function of institutional region. The mean scores for *Business of Education* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions in the Eastern (M = 3.33, SD = 0.412), Midwest (M = 3.30, SD = 0.431), Rocky Mountain (M = 3.19, SD = 0.363), Southern (M = 3.46, SD = 0.376), Southwest (M = 3.46, SD = 0.485), and Western (M = 3.40, SD = 0.347) regions, $F(5,226) = 1.825$, $p = 0.109$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test (p = 0.298).

Staff Size

To examine whether financial aid leaders' perceptions of professional competencies differ based on staff size, six one-way ANOVAs were conducted. The results are presented in Table 9. The assumption of homogeneity of variance was violated for the *Career Development* competency area ($p < 0.05$); therefore, Welch's ANOVA was used for this analysis. Post hoc tests were conducted when the one-way ANOVA results indicated statistically significant differences to identify specific group differences. Overall, a statistically significant difference was found for one competency area, *Career Development*, based on years of experience. Thus, the null hypothesis was rejected.

Table 9

Summary of One-Way ANOVA of Financial Aid Leaders' Perception of Professional Competencies as a Function of Staff Size

Variables and Source	*df*	*SS*	*MS*	*F*	*p*
Laws & Regulations					
Between Groups	4	0.321	0.080	1.004	0.406
Within Groups	219	17.520	0.080		
Career Development[a]					
Between Groups	4	0.758	0.190	3.807	0.007*
Within Groups	76	24.215	0.106		
Leadership Skills					
Between Groups	4	0.416	0.104	1.179	0.321
Within Groups	228	20.127	0.088		
Customer Service					
Between Groups	4	0.197	0.049	0.479	0.751
Within Groups	228	23.475	0.103		
Technical Proficiency					
Between Groups	4	0.269	0.067	0.399	0.809
Within Groups	230	38.774	0.169		
Business of Education					
Between Groups	4	0.682	0.170	1.018	0.399
Within Groups	227	38.014	0.167		

Note. [a] = Welch's ANOVA utilized, * = p < .05.

Beginning with the *Laws and Regulations* competency area, the analysis found no statistically significant differences across staff size categories. The mean scores for *Laws and Regulations* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions with staff sizes of 1-5 (M = 3.65, SD = 0.291), 6-10 (M = 3.60, SD = 0.300), 11-15 (M = 3.63, SD = 0.274), 16-20 (M = 3.75, SD = 0.240), and 21+ (M = 3.66, SD = 0.261), $F(4,219) = 1.004$, $p = 0.406$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.321$).

Notably, *Career Development* did demonstrate a statistically significant difference across staff sizes, making it the only area where such differences emerged. The mean scores for *Career Development* did demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions with staff sizes of 1-5 (M = 3.70, SD = 0.360), 6-10 (M = 3.70, SD =

0.352), 11-15 (M = 3.76, SD = 0.296), 16-20 (M = 3.93, SD = 0.182), and 21+ (M = 3.77, SD = 0.281), Welch's $F(4,76) = 3.807$, $p = 0.007$, $\eta^2 = 0.03$. The variances were not assumed to be equal based on the significant result of Levene's test (p = <0.001); thus, Welch's ANOVA was utilized. Eta-squared indicated a small effect size ($\eta^2 = 0.03$). A Games-Howell post hoc test was conducted, which revealed that financial aid leaders serving at institutions with a staff size of 16-20 (M = 3.93, SD = 0.182) reported mean scores statistically significantly higher than financial aid leaders with serving at institutions with a staff size of 1-5 (M = 3.70, SD = 0.360, p = 0.018) or 6-10 (M = 3.70, SD = 0.352, p = 0.008) regarding *Career Development* competencies.

Turning to *Leadership Skills*, no statistically significant differences were observed as a function of staff size. The mean scores for *Leadership Skills* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions with staff sizes of 1-5 (M = 3.55, SD = 0.329), 6-10 (M = 3.62, SD = 0.280), 11-15 (M = 3.60, SD = 0.305), 16-20 (M = 3.65, SD = 0.235), and 21+ (M = 3.68, SD = 0.299), $F(4,228) = 1.179$, $p = 0.321$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test (p = 0.247).

Similarly, the *Customer Service* competency area did not show statistically significant variation based on staff size. The mean scores for *Customer Service* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions with staff sizes of 1-5 (M = 3.60, SD = 0.290), 6-10 (M = 3.53, SD = 0.331), 11-15 (M = 3.54, SD = 0.333), 16-20 (M = 3.60, SD = 0.322), and 21+ (M = 3.59, SD = 0.325), $F(4,228) = 0.479$, $p = 0.751$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test (p = 0.915).

The pattern continued with *Technical Proficiency*, where no significant differences were found across different staff size groups. The mean scores for *Technical Proficiency* did not

demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions with staff sizes of 1-5 (M = 3.65, SD = 0.394), 6-10 (M = 3.65, SD = 0.412), 11-15 (M = 3.70, SD = 0.371), 16-20 (M = 3.55, SD = 0.533), and 21+ (M = 3.63, SD = 0.419), $F(4,230) = 0.399$, $p = 0.809$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.530$).

Finally, the *Business of Education* competency area revealed no statistically significant differences based on staff size. The mean scores for *Business of Education* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders serving at institutions with staff sizes of 1-5 (M = 3.30, SD = 0.434), 6-10 (M = 3.39, SD = 0.401), 11-15 (M = 3.35, SD = 0.446), 16-20 (M = 3.48, SD = 0.310), and 21+ (M = 3.44, SD = 0.382), $F(4,227) = 1.018$, $p = 0.399$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test (p = 0.397).

Gender Identity

To examine how financial aid leaders' perception of professional competencies differ as a function of gender identity, an independent samples t test was conducted. Due to the distribution of responses, this analysis was limited to participants who identified as either "man" or "woman." Most respondents identified as women (N = 160, 68.1%), followed by men (N = 68, 28.9%). A small number of respondents identified as non-binary (N = 2, 0.9%) or selected "prefer not to respond" (N = 5, 2.1%). While gender identity is a meaningful and complex construct, and it is possible that individuals with non-binary identities may differ in their perceptions based on their unique experiences, the number of respondents in this category was too small to support a statistical analysis. As such, non-binary and "prefer not to respond" responses were excluded from this comparison. The results of the test are presented in Table 10.

Overall, a statistically significant difference was indicated between financial aid leaders who identified as men and women for three competency areas (*Laws and Regulations, Customer Service*, and *Business of Education*). Thus, the null hypothesis was rejected.

Table 10

Summary of Independent Samples t test of Financial Aid Leaders' Perception of Professional Competencies as a Function of Gender Identity

	Man			Woman						
Variable	***N***	***M***	***SD***	***N***	***M***	***SD***	***df***	***t***	***p***	***d***
Laws & Regulations	63	3.56	0.284	154	3.66	0.279	215	-2.395	0.017*	-0.36
Career Development[a]	68	3.67	0.359	160	3.76	0.313	112	-1.696	0.093	-0.26
Leadership Skills[a]	67	3.56	0.330	160	3.62	0.281	108	-1.304	0.195	-0.20
Customer Service	67	3.48	0.348	159	3.59	0.304	224	-2.483	0.014*	-0.36
Technical Proficiency	68	3.66	0.390	160	3.65	0.414	226	0.116	0.907	0.02
Business of Education[a]	67	3.24	0.461	159	3.42	0.030	105	-2.928	0.004*	-0.46

Note. [a] = Unequal variance *t* test utilized, * = p < .05.

Starting with *Laws and Regulations*, the analysis revealed a statistically significant difference between men and women. The mean scores for *Laws and Regulations* showed a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders who identified as men (M = 356, SD = 0.284) and those who identified as women (M = 3.66, SD = 0.279), $t(215) = -2.395$, p = 0.017, d = -0.36. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test (p = 0.891). Cohen's d indicated a small-to-medium effect size (d = -0.36).

In contrast, the *Career Development* competency area did not show a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders of different gender identities. The mean scores for *Career Development* did not differ significantly between financial aid leaders who identified as men (M = 3.67, SD = 0.359) and those who identified as women (M = 3.76, SD = 0.313), $t(112) = -1.696$, p = 0.093, d = -0.2. The variances were not assumed to be equal based on the significant result of Levene's test (p = 0.007); thus, an unequal variance t test was utilized.

Similarly, the *Leadership Skills* competency area showed no significant variation. The mean scores for *Leadership Skills* did not differ significantly between financial aid leaders who identified as men (M = 3.56, SD = 0.330) and those who identified as women (M = 3.62, SD = 0.281), $t(108) = -1.304$, $p = 0.195$, $d = -0.20$. The variances were not assumed to be equal based on the significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.036$); thus, an unequal variance t test was utilized.

Turning to *Customer Service*, the analysis identified another significant difference between male and female financial aid leaders. The mean scores for *Customer Service* showed a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders who identified as men (M = 3.48, SD = 0.348) and those who identified as women (M = 3.59, SD = 0.304), $t(224) = -2.483$, $p = 0.014$, $d = -0.36$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.171$). Cohen's d indicated a small-to-medium effect size ($d = -0.36$).

For *Technical Proficiency*, no statistically significant differences were found across gender identity. The mean scores for *Technical Proficiency* did not differ significantly between financial aid leaders who identified as men (M = 3.66, SD = 0.390) and those who identified as women (M = 3.65, SD = 0.414), $t(226) = 0.116$, $p = 0.907$, $d = 0.02$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.986$).

Finally, the *Business of Education* competency area also showed a statistically significant difference, rounding out the three areas where gender identity played a meaningful role. The mean scores for *Business of Education* showed a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders who identified as men (M = 3.24, SD = 0.461) and those who identified as women (M = 3.42, SD = 0.030), $t(105) = -2.928$, $p = 0.004$, $d = -0.46$. The variances were not assumed to be equal based on the significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.020$); thus, an unequal variance t test was utilized. Cohen's d indicated a medium effect size ($d = -0.46$).

Overall, the competency areas that exhibited a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders who identified as men and women were *Laws and Regulations, Customer Service*, and *Business of Education*. In all three cases, financial aid leaders who identified as women reported higher mean scores than those who identified as men.

Race/Ethnicity

To examine how financial aid leaders' perceptions of professional competencies differ as a function of race/ethnicity, an independent samples *t* test was conducted. For statistical analysis, race/ethnicity was grouped into two categories: White and non-White. The sample was predominantly White/Caucasian ($N = 176$, 74.9%). Other racial/ethnic identities included Black or African American ($N = 23$, 9.8%), Hispanic ($N = 20$, 8.5%), Asian/Pacific Islander ($N = 4$, 1.7%), and American Indian or Alaskan Native ($N = 3$, 1.3%). A small number of participants identified with a race/ethnicity not listed ($N = 3$, 1.3%) or selected "prefer not to respond" ($N = 6$, 2.6%). Due to the small number of respondents in each non-White group, a disaggregated analysis was not statistically feasible. As a result, all non-White identities were grouped together for comparative purposes. While this approach limits the ability to examine nuanced differences across racial/ethnic groups, it allowed for a more reliable statistical comparison within the constraints of the available data. Responses selecting "prefer not to respond" were excluded from the analysis. The results are presented in Table 11. Overall, a statistically significant difference was indicated between financial aid leaders who identified as White and non-White for four competency areas (*Career Development*, *Customer Service*, *Technical Proficiency*, and *Business of Education*). Thus, the null hypothesis was rejected.

Table 11

Summary of Independent Samples t test of Financial Aid Leaders' Perception of Professional Competencies as a Function of Race/Ethnicity

	White			Non-White						
Variable	***N***	***M***	***SD***	***N***	***M***	***SD***	***df***	***t***	***p***	***d***
Laws & Regulations	165	3.63	0.286	53	3.66	0.274	216	-0.600	0.549	-0.10
Career Development[a]	175	3.69	0.341	53	3.87	0.248	117	-4.209	<0.001*	-0.56
Leadership Skills	174	3.58	0.302	53	3.67	0.278	225	-1.833	0.068	-0.29
Customer Service	175	3.52	0.318	52	3.69	0.288	225	-3.462	<0.001*	-0.55
Technical Proficiency[a]	176	3.62	0.426	53	3.77	0.297	123	-2.888	0.005*	-0.37
Business of Education[a]	173	3.32	0.420	53	3.52	0.342	104	-3.503	<0.001*	-0.49

Note. [a] = Unequal variance *t* test utilized, * = p < .05.

Beginning with the *Laws and Regulations* competency area, the analysis found no statistically significant differences between White and non-White financial aid leaders. The mean scores for *Laws and Regulations* did not differ significantly between financial aid leaders who identified as White (M = 3.63, SD = 0.286) and those who identified as non-White (M = 3.66, SD = 0.274), $t(216) = -0.600$, $p = 0.549$, $d = -0.36$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.520$).

In contrast, *Career Development* revealed a statistically significant difference between the two racial/ethnic groups. The mean scores for *Career Development* showed a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders who identified as White (M = 3.69, SD = 0.341) and those who identified as non-White (M = 3.87, SD = 0.248), $t(117) = -4.209$, p = <0.001, $d = -0.56$. The variances were not assumed to be equal based on the significant result of Levene's test (p = <0.001); thus, an unequal variance *t* test was utilized. Cohen's *d* indicated a medium effect size ($d = -0.56$).

Turning to *Leadership Skills*, the results indicated no meaningful differences based on race/ethnicity. The mean scores for *Leadership Skills* did not differ significantly between financial aid leaders who identified as White (M = 3.58, SD = 0.302) and those who identified as

non-White (M = 3.67, SD = 0.278), $t(225)$ = -1.833, p = 0.068, d = -0.29. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test (p = 0.246).

However, *Customer Service* showed a significant difference between White and non-White financial aid leaders. The mean scores for *Customer Service* showed a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders who identified as White (M = 3.52, SD = 0.318) and those who identified as non-White (M = 3.69, SD = 0.288), $t(225)$ = -3.462, p = <0.001, d = -0.55. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test (p = 0.290). Cohen's d indicated a medium effect size (d = -0.55).

A similar statistically significant difference was observed for *Technical Proficiency*. The mean scores for *Technical Proficiency* showed a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders who identified as White (M = 3.62, SD = 0.426) and those who identified as non-White (M = 3.77, SD = 0.297), $t(123)$ = -2.888, p = 0.005, d = -0.37. The variances were not assumed to be equal based on the significant result of Levene's test (p = 0.001); thus, an unequal variance t test was utilized. Cohen's d indicated a small-to-medium effect size (d = -0.37).

Finally, the *Business of Education* competency area also exhibited a statistically significant difference between the two groups. The mean scores for *Business of Education* showed a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders who identified as White (M = 3.32, SD = 0.420) and those who identified as non-White (M = 3.52, SD = 0.342), $t(104)$ = -3.503, p = <0.001, d = -0.49. The variances were not assumed to be equal based on the significant result of Levene's test (p = 0.026); thus, an unequal variance t test was utilized. Cohen's d indicated a medium effect size (d = -0.49).

Overall, the competency areas that exhibited a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders who identified as White and non-White were *Career Development*,

Customer Service, *Technical Proficiency*, and *Business of Education*. In all four cases, financial aid leaders who identified as non-White reported higher mean scores than those who identified as White.

Age

To examine whether financial aid leaders' perceptions of professional competencies differ based on age, six one-way ANOVAs were conducted. The results are presented in Table 12. Post hoc tests were conducted when the one-way ANOVA results indicated statistically significant differences to identify specific group differences. Overall, a statistically significant difference was found for one competency area, *Laws and Regulations*, based on age. Thus, the null hypothesis was rejected.

Table 12

Summary of One-Way ANOVA of Financial Aid Leaders' Perception of Professional Competencies as a Function of Age

Variables and Source	***df***	***SS***	***MS***	***F***	***p***
Laws & Regulations					
Between Groups	4	0.920	0.230	2.977	0.020*
Within Groups	219	16.921	0.077		
Career Development[a]					
Between Groups	4	0.445	0.111	1.257	0.302
Within Groups	41	24.528	0.107		
Leadership Skills					
Between Groups	4	0.045	0.011	0.125	0.973
Within Groups	228	20.498	0.090		
Customer Service					
Between Groups	4	0.273	0.068	0.665	0.617
Within Groups	228	23.399	0.103		
Technical Proficiency					
Between Groups	4	0.398	0.099	0.592	0.669
Within Groups	230	38.645	0.168		
Business of Education					
Between Groups	4	0.071	0.018	0.105	0.981
Within Groups	227	38.624	0.170		

Note. [a] = Welch's ANOVA utilized, * = $p < .05$.

Beginning with the *Laws and Regulations* competency area, the analysis identified a statistically significant difference across age groups. The mean scores for *Laws and Regulations* did demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders aged 25-34 (M = 3.53, SD = 0.317), 35-44 (M = 3.56, SD = 0.304), 45-54 (M = 3.68, SD = 0.261), 55-64 (M = 3.65, SD = 0.279), and 65 and over (M = 3.80, SD = 0.188), $F(4,219) = 2.977$, $p = 0.020$, $\eta^2 = 0.05$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.187$). Eta-squared indicated a small-to-medium effect size ($\eta^2 = 0.05$). However, while the one-way ANOVA indicated a statistically significant difference among the groups, Tukey's post hoc test did not reveal any significant differences between individual group pairs. To further investigate, Duncan's post hoc test was employed. Duncan's post hoc test revealed that financial aid leaders aged 65 and over (M = 3.80, SD = 0.188) reported mean scores statistically significantly higher than financial aid leaders aged 25-34 (M = 3.53, SD = 0.317, $p = 0.033$) or 35-44 (M = 3.56, SD = 0.304, $p = 0.010$) in relation to *Laws and Regulations* competencies. Additionally, Duncan's post hoc test revealed that financial aid leaders aged 45-54 (M = 3.68, SD = 0.261) reported mean scores statistically significantly higher ($p = 0.010$) than financial aid leaders aged 35-44 (M = 3.56, SD = 0.304).

In contrast, the *Career Development* competency area did not show any statistically significant differences based on age. The mean scores for *Career Development* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders aged 25-34 (M = 3.77, SD = 0.328), 35-44 (M = 3.71, SD = 0.370), 45-54 (M = 3.70, SD = 0.340), 55-64 (M = 3.81, SD = 0.258), and 65 and over (M = 3.75, SD = 0.296), Welch's $F(4,41) = 1.257$, $p = 0.302$. The variances were not assumed to be equal based on the significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.004$); thus, Welch's ANOVA was utilized.

Similarly, *Leadership Skills* demonstrated no statistically significant variation among the different age groups. The mean scores for *Leadership Skills* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders aged 25-34 (M = 3.61, SD = 0.311), 35-44 (M = 3.61, SD = 0.306), 45-54 (M = 3.61, SD = 0.304), 55-64 (M = 3.61, SD = 0.282), and 65 and over (M = 3.67, SD = 0.317), $F(4,228) = 0.125$, $p = 0.973$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.898$).

The pattern continued for *Customer Service*, where no statistically significant differences were found by age. The mean scores for *Customer Service* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders aged 25-34 (M = 3.46, SD = 0.413), 35-44 (M = 3.60, SD = 0.304), 45-54 (M = 3.57, SD = 0.335), 55-64 (M = 3.54, SD = 0.303), and 65 and over (M = 3.58, SD = 0.267), $F(4,228) = 0.665$, $p = 0.617$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.412$).

Technical Proficiency also showed no meaningful differences across the age groups analyzed. The mean scores for *Technical Proficiency* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders aged 25-34 (M = 3.61, SD = 0.446), 35-44 (M = 3.59, SD = 0.431), 45-54 (M = 3.68, SD = 0.399), 55-64 (M = 3.68, SD = 0.385), and 65 and over (M = 3.64, SD = 0.458), $F(4,230) = 0.592$, $p = 0.669$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.828$).

Finally, the *Business of Education* competency area did not reveal any significant differences as a function of age. The mean scores for *Business of Education* did not demonstrate a statistically significant difference between financial aid leaders aged 25-34 (M = 3.38, SD = 0.478), 35-44 (M = 3.36, SD = 0.452), 45-54 (M = 3.37, SD = 0.425), 55-64 (M = 3.40, SD =

0.344), and 65 and over (M = 3.34, SD = 0.349), $F(4,227) = 0.105$, $p = 0.981$. The variances were assumed to be equal based on the non-significant result of Levene's test ($p = 0.095$).

Research Question 3

The third research question guiding this study was: "How are professional competencies for effective practice as a financial aid leader developed?" Having established which competencies are perceived as most important, and how those perceptions vary, the final research question examines how financial aid leaders develop these competencies—shifting focus from competency identification to competency acquisition. While prior literature has outlined various strategies—such as certification programs, mentoring, and cross-training—little empirical research has addressed which methods are most used or most valued by leaders in the financial aid profession. By examining how competencies are developed in practice, this study contributes to the advancement of leadership capacity-building within financial aid and provides actionable insights for institutions, associations, and individuals invested in leadership development and helps bridge the gap between theoretical frameworks and applied practice.

Tables 13 through 18 present frequencies and percentages for the methods and resources financial aid leaders reported as most effective for developing competencies related to the six primary competency areas—*Laws and Regulations*, *Career Development*, *Leadership Skills*, *Customer Service*, *Technical Proficiency*, and *Business of Education*. Participants were allowed to select up to three options for each area.

Laws and Regulations

Respondent selections for competency development related to *Laws and Regulations* are presented in Table 13. A total of 30 respondents (12.8%) indicated that they found formal education through a degree or certificate program useful. Sixty-one respondents (26.0%) selected

the NASFAA Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program. The Federal Student Aid (FSA) Training Center learning tracks and training courses were chosen by 100 respondents (42.6%). NASFAA resources, including conferences, webinars, and the AskRegs database, were identified by 189 respondents (80.4%). FSA resources, such as conferences, webinars, and the Student Aid Handbook, were cited by 169 respondents (71.9%). Other conferences and webinars not hosted by NASFAA or FSA were selected by 47 respondents (20.0%). Industry-related materials such as books, journals, blogs, and podcasts were identified by 5 respondents (2.1%). Networking or mentorship was selected by 73 respondents (31.1%), while job shadowing or cross-training was chosen by 26 respondents (11.1%).

Table 13

Methods and Resources for Competency Development in Laws and Regulations

Method or Resource	***N***	***%***
Formal Education (Degree/Certificate Program)	30	12.8%
National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA) Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program	61	26.0%
Federal Student Aid (FSA) Training Center Learning Tracks/Training Courses	100	42.6%
NASFAA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, AskRegs Database)	189	80.4%
FSA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, Student Aid Handbook)	169	71.9%
Other Conferences and Webinars (Not hosted by NASFAA or FSA)	47	20.0%
Industry-Related Materials (Books, Journals, Blogs, Podcasts)	5	2.1%
Networking/Mentorship	73	31.1%
Job Shadowing/Cross-Training	26	11.1%

Career Development

Respondent selections for competency development related to *Career Development* are presented in Table 14. Formal education through a degree or certificate program was selected by 89 respondents (37.9%). Fifty-eight respondents (24.7%) indicated the NASFAA Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program. The FSA Training Center's learning tracks and training courses were identified by 55 respondents (23.4%). NASFAA resources, such as conferences,

webinars, and the AskRegs database, were selected by 125 respondents (53.2%). Sixty-nine respondents (29.4%) cited FSA resources, including conferences, webinars, and the Student Aid Handbook. Other conferences and webinars not hosted by NASFAA or FSA were selected by 86 respondents (36.6%). Fourteen respondents (6.0%) identified industry-related materials like books, blogs, or podcasts. Networking or mentorship was selected by 142 respondents (60.4%), and 48 respondents (20.4%) identified job shadowing or cross-training.

Table 14

Methods and Resources for Competency Development in Career Development

Method or Resource	***N***	***%***
Formal Education (Degree/Certificate Program)	89	37.9%
National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA) Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program	58	24.7%
Federal Student Aid (FSA) Training Center Learning Tracks/Training Courses	55	23.4%
NASFAA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, AskRegs Database)	125	53.2%
FSA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, Student Aid Handbook)	69	29.4%
Other Conferences and Webinars (Not hosted by NASFAA or FSA)	86	36.6%
Industry-Related Materials (Books, Journals, Blogs, Podcasts)	14	6.0%
Networking/Mentorship	142	60.4%
Job Shadowing/Cross-Training	48	20.4%

Leadership Skills

Respondent selections for competency development related to *Leadership Skills* are presented in Table 15. For this competency area, 139 respondents (59.1%) indicated that formal education supported their development. The NASFAA Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program was cited by 24 respondents (10.2%), and 20 respondents (8.5%) selected the FSA Training Center learning tracks and training courses. Seventy-seven respondents (32.8%) referenced NASFAA resources, while 33 (14.0%) selected FSA materials. Other non-NASFAA or FSA webinars and conferences were used by 94 respondents (40.0%). Fifty-one respondents

(21.7%) pointed to industry-related materials. The most reported resource was networking or mentorship, selected by 173 respondents (73.6%). Job shadowing or cross-training was noted by 60 respondents (25.5%).

Table 15

Methods and Resources for Competency Development in Leadership Skills

Method or Resource	***N***	***%***
Formal Education (Degree/Certificate Program)	139	59.1%
National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA) Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program	24	10.2%
Federal Student Aid (FSA) Training Center Learning Tracks/Training Courses	20	8.5%
NASFAA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, AskRegs Database)	77	32.8%
FSA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, Student Aid Handbook)	33	14.0%
Other Conferences and Webinars (Not hosted by NASFAA or FSA)	94	40.0%
Industry-Related Materials (Books, Journals, Blogs, Podcasts)	51	21.7%
Networking/Mentorship	173	73.6%
Job Shadowing/Cross-Training	60	25.5%

Customer Service

Respondent selections for competency development related to *Customer Service* are presented in Table 16. Seventy-four respondents (31.5%) indicated the use of formal education programs. Eleven respondents (4.7%) selected the NASFAA Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program, while 15 respondents (6.4%) cited the FSA Training Center. NASFAA resources were chosen by 66 respondents (28.1%), and FSA resources were also cited by 15 respondents (6.4%). Other webinars and conferences not affiliated with NASFAA or FSA were referenced by 125 respondents (53.2%). Fifty respondents (21.3%) identified industry-related materials. Networking or mentorship was selected by 153 respondents (65.1%), and job shadowing or cross-training by 123 respondents (52.3%).

Table 16

Methods and Resources for Competency Development in Customer Service

Method or Resource	***N***	***%***
Formal Education (Degree/Certificate Program)	74	31.5%
National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA) Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program	11	4.7%
Federal Student Aid (FSA) Training Center Learning Tracks/Training Courses	15	6.4%
NASFAA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, AskRegs Database)	66	28.1%
FSA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, Student Aid Handbook)	15	6.4%
Other Conferences and Webinars (Not hosted by NASFAA or FSA)	125	53.2%
Industry-Related Materials (Books, Journals, Blogs, Podcasts)	50	21.3%
Networking/Mentorship	153	65.1%
Job Shadowing/Cross-Training	123	52.3%

Technical Proficiency

Respondent selections for competency development related to *Customer Service* are presented in Table 17. Eighty respondents (34.0%) found formal education helpful. Thirteen respondents (5.5%) selected the NASFAA Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program, and 43 respondents (18.3%) identified the FSA Training Center. NASFAA resources were selected by 65 respondents (27.7%), and 49 respondents (20.9%) referenced FSA resources. Other non-NASFAA or FSA conferences and webinars were used by 139 respondents (59.1%). Fifty-four respondents (23.0%) reported using industry-related materials. Networking or mentorship was cited by 109 respondents (46.4%), and 96 respondents (40.9%) indicated that job shadowing or cross-training was utilized for competency development.

Table 17

Methods and Resources for Competency Development in Technical Proficiency

Method or Resource	***N***	***%***
Formal Education (Degree/Certificate Program)	80	34.0%
National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA) Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program	13	5.5%
Federal Student Aid (FSA) Training Center Learning Tracks/Training Courses	43	18.3%
NASFAA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, AskRegs Database)	65	27.7%
FSA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, Student Aid Handbook)	49	20.9%
Other Conferences and Webinars (Not hosted by NASFAA or FSA)	139	59.1%
Industry-Related Materials (Books, Journals, Blogs, Podcasts)	54	23.0%
Networking/Mentorship	109	46.4%
Job Shadowing/Cross-Training	96	40.9%

Business of Education

Respondent selections for competency development related to *Customer Service* are presented in Table 18. Formal education was selected by 116 respondents (49.4%). The NASFAA Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program was indicated by 15 respondents (6.4%), and the FSA Training Center by 32 respondents (13.6%). NASFAA resources were cited by 71 respondents (30.2%), while FSA resources were selected by 36 respondents (15.3%). Ninety-six respondents (40.9%) utilized other conferences and webinars not hosted by NASFAA or FSA. Industry-related materials were selected by 54 respondents (23.0%). Networking or mentorship was noted by 132 respondents (56.2%), and 70 respondents (29.8%) identified job shadowing or cross-training as useful.

Table 18

Methods and Resources for Competency Development in Business of Education

Method or Resource	***N***	***%***
Formal Education (Degree/Certificate Program)	116	49.4%
National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA) Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program	15	6.4%
Federal Student Aid (FSA) Training Center Learning Tracks/Training Courses	32	13.6%
NASFAA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, AskRegs Database)	71	30.2%
FSA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, Student Aid Handbook)	36	15.3%
Other Conferences and Webinars (Not hosted by NASFAA or FSA)	96	40.9%
Industry-Related Materials (Books, Journals, Blogs, Podcasts)	54	23.0%
Networking/Mentorship	132	56.2%
Job Shadowing/Cross-Training	70	29.8%

Summary

This study employed a quantitative research methodology to examine financial aid leaders' perceptions regarding the importance of professional competencies for success in their roles, as well as the ways in which these competencies are developed. A total of 235 financial aid leaders from public colleges and universities across the United States participated in the study. The sample was broadly representative of the U.S. public higher education landscape, based on several key demographic and institutional characteristics. Participant demographics were detailed in Table 3. Three primary research questions guided this investigation.

The first research question explored the perceived importance of six professional competency areas. Descriptive statistics were used to analyze the mean scores reported by participants, with results presented in Table 4. The competencies were ranked as follows: *Career Development* ($M = 3.73$, $SD = 0.365$), *Technical Proficiency* ($M = 3.65$, $SD = 0.408$), *Laws and Regulations* ($M = 3.60$, $SD = 0.337$) and *Leadership Skills* ($M = 3.60$, $SD = 0.312$), *Customer Service* ($M = 3.56$, $SD = 0.331$), and *Business of Education* ($M = 3.35$, $SD = 0.450$).

The second research question examined whether perceptions of professional competencies varied according to demographic and institutional characteristics, including years of experience, institutional type, institutional size, institutional region, staff size, gender identity, race/ethnicity, and age. Inferential statistical analyses—including one-way ANOVA and independent samples *t* tests—were conducted, with results specified in Tables 5 through 14. Table 19 summarizes statistically significant findings ($p < 0.05$), where differences in mean scores across various competency areas as a function of the independent variables were identified. Specifically:

- *Laws and Regulations*: Statistically significant differences based on institutional type, gender identity, and age.
- *Career Development*: Statistically significant differences based on institutional type, staff size, and race/ethnicity.
- *Customer Service*: Statistically significant differences based on institutional type, gender identity, and race/ethnicity.
- *Technical Proficiency*: Statistically significant differences based on institutional type and race/ethnicity.
- *Business of Education*: Statistically significant differences based on years of experience, institutional type, gender identity, and race/ethnicity.

The third research question aimed to understand how financial aid leaders develop professional competencies. For each of the six competency areas, participants selected up to three of nine predefined methods and resources that contributed to their development. The results, presented in Tables 13 through 18, revealed patterns of professional development for each competency area.

Table 19

Summary of Significant Results

Competency Area	Independent Variables	Area of Significance
Laws & Regulations	Institutional Type	2-Year > 4-Year
	Gender Identity	Woman > Man
	Age	65+ > 25-34
		65+ > 35-44
		45-54 > 35-44
Career Development	Institutional Type	2-Year > 4-Year
	Staff Size	16-20 > 1-5
		16-20 > 6-10
	Race/Ethnicity	Non-White > White
Customer Service	Institutional Type	2-Year > 4-Year
	Gender Identity	Woman > Man
	Race/Ethnicity	Non-White > White
Technical Proficiency	Institutional Type	2-Year > 4-Year
	Race/Ethnicity	Non-White > White
Business of Education	Years of Experience	1-5 Years > 16-20 Years
		6-10 Years > 16-20 Years
	Institutional Type	2-Year > 4-Year
	Gender Identity	Woman > Man
	Race/Ethnicity	Non-White > White

CHAPTER V

DISCUSSION

This chapter synthesizes the data presented in Chapter IV and situates the findings within the broader scholarly context explored in Chapter II. It offers interpretations, draws connections, and highlights key insights regarding the professional competencies required of financial aid leaders in public U.S. higher education. Organized around the study's three primary research questions, the discussion provides the foundation for examining implications for practice, study limitations, and future research directions. The three research questions guiding this study were:

1. How do financial aid leaders perceive the importance of professional competencies to success in their role?
2. How do financial aid leaders' perceptions of professional competencies differ as a function of:
    - Years of Experience
    - Institutional Type
    - Institutional Size
    - Institutional Region
    - Staff Size
    - Gender Identity
    - Race/Ethnicity
    - Age
3. How are professional competencies for effective practice as a financial aid leader developed?

By systematically addressing each question, this chapter reveals both the theoretical and practical significance of the findings and offers actionable insights for advancing leadership capacity in the financial aid profession.

Review of Key Findings

This study revealed several key insights into the perceptions and development of professional competencies among financial aid leaders at public colleges and universities in the United States. Leaders overwhelmingly value competencies related to career development, technical proficiency, leadership, and regulatory knowledge. Additionally, perceptions of competency importance vary meaningfully across certain demographic and institutional characteristics, highlighting the role of environment, experience, and identity in shaping leadership priorities, and underscoring the need for context-specific, focused training. Financial aid leaders also draw on diverse methods and resources to develop these competencies—including mentorship, formal education, specialized training, and experiential learning—with notable preferences across competency areas. Collectively, these findings emphasize the necessity of designing intentional, inclusive, and adaptive professional development efforts to build a sustainable leadership pipeline.

Participant Characteristics

The participant sample represented a broad cross-section of institutional types, with nearly equal representation from public two-year (50.6%) and four-year (49.3%) colleges and universities. The sample also included institutions of varying sizes—from fewer than 500 to more than 10,000 full-time equivalent (FTE) students—ensuring that small, medium, and large campuses were represented. Additionally, respondents spanned all major U.S. regions, with relatively even distribution, contributing to the national scope of the study. Professional

backgrounds ranged from newer to seasoned leaders working within financial aid offices of varying capacities. Although the sample was not highly diverse in terms of gender or racial/ethnic composition, the study meaningfully explored these dimensions through two-category comparisons (men and women; White and non-White). Overall, the participant profile offered a broad and reasonably representative snapshot of financial aid leaders and institutions, enhancing the generalizability of the study's findings within the context of public higher education in the United States.

A critical demographic insight is that a substantial portion of current financial aid leaders included in this sample were aged 45 and above, raising concerns about impending retirements and the need for proactive succession planning. To preserve institutional knowledge and ensure leadership continuity, there is an urgency to create and prioritize structured pathways for advancing and developing future leaders (Bolton & Roy, 2004; Ritchie 2020).

Research Question 1

The findings from Research Question 1 revealed how financial aid leaders perceive the importance of professional competencies to success in their roles. Leaders viewed professional competencies as highly important, with most competency areas receiving mean scores above 3.50 on a 4-point scale (Table 4). Among the six major competency areas, *Career Development* (M = 3.73, SD = 0.365) and *Technical Proficiency* (M = 3.65, SD = 0.408) received the highest mean importance ratings, indicating the strong emphasis that financial aid leaders place on continuous growth, skill development, and technological competence. The equal mean scores of the *Laws and Regulations* (M = 3.60, SD = 0.337) and *Leadership Skills* (M = 3.60, SD = 0.312) competency areas demonstrate the multifaceted demands of financial aid leadership. The findings reveal that financial aid leaders view both regulatory expertise and leadership capability

as central to their efficiency, supporting early literature highlighting the unique blend of skills that this role requires (Barry, 1974).

Although *Customer Service* (M = 3.56, SD = 0.331) and *Business of Education* (M = 3.35, SD = 0.450) were rated slightly lower, financial aid leaders still value them. Encompassing competencies related to advising, empathy, institutional governance, and risk assessment, the relatively lower ratings do not diminish the significance of these two competency areas, but rather indicate that competencies related to regulatory knowledge, technical skill, and leadership are prioritized in the financial aid leader role.

Together, these findings highlight that financial aid leadership continues to require a versatile combination of technical, regulatory, strategic, and developmental competencies, which may not be necessarily surprising considering the broad responsibilities required of financial aid administrators (Giblin & Morris, 2021; NASFAA, 2022; Sanders, 2021; Woolf, 2012). The findings align with Northouse's (2015) skills-based approach to leadership theory, which posits that effective leadership is grounded in abilities that can be learned and refined over time, rather than traits inherent to an individual. If the competencies most valued by financial aid leaders are learnable and developable, institutions have a clear opportunity—and responsibility—to invest in training and leadership pipelines that prepare future leaders to meet evolving demands. As institutions and organizations consider the need for leadership pathways and succession planning (Bolton & Roy, 2004)—which are especially critical considering the increasing staff turnover, growing regulatory complexity, and heightened performance expectations facing higher education institutions (Marshall et al., 2016; NASFAA 2023a)—they must consider the design of professional development initiatives. This not only relies on understanding the competencies valued, but how institutional or individual factors may influence them.

Research Question 2

The findings from Research Question 2 demonstrated how financial aid leaders' perceptions of professional competencies vary based on institutional and individual characteristics. Specifically, the analyses examined years of experience, institutional type, institutional size, institutional region, staff size, gender identity, race/ethnicity, and age, revealing multiple statistically significant patterns (Table 19).

Institutional characteristics showed statistically significant differences. This supports prior literature emphasizing that institutional context shapes leadership demands (Hossler & Kemerer, 1986). Financial aid leaders at two-year institutions rated competencies related to *Technical Proficiency*, *Customer Service*, and *Business of Education* statistically significantly higher than those at four-year institutions. Leaders at smaller or less-resourced institutions may maintain broader, direct responsibilities while leaders at larger or more-resourced institutions may focus more on strategy and delegation. Similarly, staff size mattered; financial aid leaders serving in offices with 16-20 staff members (M = 3.93, SD = 0.182) reported statistically significantly higher mean scores for *Career Development* than financial aid leaders in offices with staff sizes of 1-5 (M = 3.70, SD = 0.360) or 6-10 (M = 3.70, SD = 0.352), indicating that as office size increases, so does career development as a leadership priority. This is potentially due to increased complexity of organizational dynamics and team management with larger groups.

Individual characteristics of respondents also revealed meaningful variation. The analysis of *Business of Education* competencies revealed statistically significant differences across financial aid leaders' years of experience, with a medium effect size (η^2 = 0.06). Specifically, leaders with 1–5 years (M = 3.47, SD = 0.418) and 6–10 years (M = 3.47, SD = 0.376) of experience reported significantly higher mean importance scores compared to leaders with 16–20

years of experience (*M* = 3.13, *SD* = 0.307). This may suggest that early-career financial aid leaders place greater emphasis on understanding institutional context, interdepartmental practices, and the models of governance and accreditation—perhaps because they are still learning how their work integrates into institutional strategy. In contrast, mid-to-late-career leaders may shift their focus toward other leadership domains, such as regulatory expertise, mentoring, or team management, perceiving business knowledge as either already mastered or less central to their current leadership effectiveness.

Additionally, the data showed that older financial aid leaders placed statistically significantly higher importance on *Laws and Regulations* competencies compared to their younger colleagues. Specifically, leaders aged 65+ (*M* = 3.80, *SD* = 0.188) rated these competencies higher than those aged 25-34 (*M* = 3.53, *SD* = 0.317) and 35-44 (*M* = 3.56, *SD* = 0.304), with leaders aged 45-54 (*M* = 3.68, *SD* = 0.261) also rating them higher than those 35-44 (*M* = 3.56, *SD* = 0.304). While the overall effect size ($\eta^2 = 0.05$) was small-to-medium, the pattern indicates generational or experiential differences in how regulatory knowledge is valued. Older leaders may have witnessed increasing regulatory complexity over time and therefore place greater importance on legal knowledge and compliance. Conversely, younger leaders may emphasize other competencies such as technology, communication, and innovation, possibly reflecting different career stage priorities and responsibilities.

Gender differences appeared across three of the six competency areas explored. Women reported statistically significantly higher mean scores in the areas of *Laws and Regulations*, *Customer Service*, and *Business of Education* compared to men. These findings point to the need for gender-sensitive development programs that acknowledge different leadership priorities and provide supportive environments for all leaders to thrive. Race and ethnicity differences further

emphasized the importance of equity-minded development. Non-White financial aid leaders reported statistically significantly higher mean scores in *Career Development*, *Customer Service*, *Technical Proficiency*, and *Business of Education* compared to White leaders. The consistently higher emphasis on these competencies may suggest that women and non-White leaders perceive a heightened need to excel in order to address or counteract systemic barriers and underscores the importance of inclusive professional development pathways that explicitly address the needs, challenges, and strengths of these groups.

Overall, the findings for Research Question 2 highlight that financial aid leaders' perceptions of key competencies are shaped through organizational context, as well as by individual background and lived experience. Instititional differences call for development strategies tailored to the demands of varying campus environments, while demographic differences point to the need for inclusive, equity-centered approaches that recognize and support diverse leadership journeys. These insights lay the groundwork for the practical recommendations that will follow later in the chapter.

Research Question 3

This section addresses Research Question 3 by interpreting the patterns revealed in Tables 13–18, which summarized the most frequently used methods and resources financial aid leaders reported for developing the six competency areas. These findings provide insights into how leaders cultivate the skills essential to their roles. For the development of *Laws and Regulations* competencies, participants overwhelmingly favored domain-specific resources. NASFAA resources (N = 189, 80.4%) and FSA resources (N = 169, 71.9%) were the most frequently cited, stressing the centrality of national organizations and authoritative agencies in equipping leaders to meet regulatory demands. The prominent use of the FSA Training Center (N

= 100, 42.6%) further highlights the importance of specialized, targeted training. Conversely, formal education (*N* = 30, 12.8%) and job shadowing or cross-training (*N* = 26, 11.1%) were less commonly reported, suggesting that regulatory expertise is perceived as best acquired through structured channels rather than general academic study or informal or experiential practice.

The development of *Career Development* competencies revealed a different emphasis. Here, networking and mentorship (*N* = 142, 60.4%) emerged as the most frequently used resource, reflecting the relational and personalized nature of career advancement in the financial aid field. NASFAA resources (*N* = 125, 53.2%) and formal education (*N* = 89, 37.9%) also played prominent roles, suggesting that both peer interactions and structured learning opportunities are valued. This finding supports existing literature that connects mentorship to employee retention and career growth and describes the need for individuals to balance formal preparation with access to experienced mentors and networks (Bolton & Roy, 2004; Marshall et al., 2016). Conversely, the FSA Training Center (*N* = 55, 23.4%) and NASFAA's Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program (*N* = 58, 24.7%) were less commonly selected—perhaps indicating that career progression relies less on domain-based training and more on broader professional development supports.

For *Leadership Skills*, the focus on networking and mentorship was even stronger, with nearly three-quarters of respondents (*N* = 173, 73.6%) citing this as a key resource. Formal education (*N* = 139, 59.1%) was also highly valued, pointing to the importance of academic preparation in cultivating leadership capacity. However, NASFAA (*N* = 77, 32.8%) and FSA resources (*N* = 33, 14.0%), along with the NASFAA Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program (*N* = 24, 10.2%) and the FSA Training Center (*N* = 20, 8.5%), were less frequently

selected. This suggests that leadership competencies are often developed through broader, cross-disciplinary learning and engagement.

In the area of *Customer Service*, respondents most cited networking and mentorship (*N* = 153, 65.1%), other conferences and webinars not hosted by NASFAA or FSA (*N* = 125, 53.2%), and job shadowing/cross-training (*N* = 123, 52.3%), emphasizing experiential and interpersonal learning methods. In contrast, the FSA Training Center (*N* = 15, 6.4%), FSA resources (*N* = 15, 6.4%), and the NASFAA Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program (*N* = 11, 4.7%) were least selected. These findings support the idea that customer service skills are more often honed through practice, observation, and peer exchange rather than formal, technical training.

For *Technical Proficiency*, participants most frequently selected other conferences and webinars not hosted by NASFAA or FSA (*N* = 139, 59.1%), networking and mentorship (*N* = 109, 46.4%) and job shadowing or cross-training (*N* = 96, 40.9%). This indicates a preference for practical, peer-based learning in technical areas. Resources including FSA materials (*N* = 49, 20.9%), the FSA Training Center (*N* = 43, 18.3%), and the NASFAA Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program (*N* = 13, 5.5%) were less utilized, possibly due to the wide variation in systems and technologies operated across institutions.

Finally, in developing *Business of Education* competencies, top resources included networking and mentorship (*N* = 132, 56.2%), formal education (*N* = 116, 49.4%), and other conferences and webinars not hosted by NASFAA or FSA (*N* = 96, 40.9%). These selections highlight the importance of both peer learning and structured academic preparation in equipping leaders to navigate broader institutional responsibilities. The least cited resources were FSA materials (*N* = 36, 15.3%), the FSA Training Center (*N* = 32, 13.6%), and the NASFAA Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program (*N* = 15, 6.4%).

Overall, the results across Tables 13–18 reveal key trends in how financial aid professionals approach competency development. First, networking and mentorship consistently emerged as a highly valued method for development, ranking among the top selections in every category and peaking in areas such as *Leadership Skills* (*N* = 173, 73.6%), *Customer Service* (*N* = 153, 65.1%), and *Career Development* (*N* = 142, 60.4%). This underscores the critical role of professional relationships and communities of practice in leadership development (Marshall et al., 2016). Second, formal education was highly valued for *Leadership Skills* (*N* = 139, 59.1%) and *Business of Education* (*N* = 116, 49.4%); however, it was less influential in compliance- or service-oriented areas such as *Laws and Regulations* (*N* = 30, 12.8%) and *Customer Service* (*N* = 74, 31.5%). Whereas domain-specific options including NASFAA resources (*N* = 189, 80.4%), FSA resources (*N* = 169, 17.9%), and the FSA Training Center (*N* = 100, 42.6%) were particularly prominent in *Laws and Regulations*. The development methods chosen by financial aid leaders for these areas are indicative of the broader, cross-functional nature of leadership and business acumen, as compared to the specific regulatory responsibilities that financial aid leaders oversee. Third, experiential methods such as job shadowing or cross-training were important for *Customer Service* (*N* = 123, 52.3%) and *Technical Proficiency* (*N* = 96, 40.9%), reflecting the hands-on nature of these skills. Additionally, other conferences and webinars not hosted by NASFAA or FSA were widely utilized, particularly for developing both *Technical Proficiency* (*N* = 139, 59.1%) and *Customer Service* (*N* = 125, 53.2%), as well.

These patterns point to the need for a blended approach to professional development—one that integrates peer engagement, formal instruction, specialized training, and experiential learning. As financial aid leaders navigate increasingly complex regulatory environments, evolving institutional priorities, and diverse student needs, professional development efforts

should be tailored to match the specific competency demands of their roles. The emphasis on ongoing professional development underscores that leadership preparation is not a one-time event but a continuous, evolving process. By understanding how leaders currently develop these competencies, institutions and professional organizations can design more targeted and effective initiatives to strengthen the financial aid profession. These findings point to several critical areas for practical attention, particularly around succession planning, specific skill-building, and inclusive leadership development.

Limitations

While the study offers valuable insights, its limitations should be acknowledged. Although the sample was broadly representative, it lacked racial and ethnic diversity, potentially limiting generalizability across underrepresented groups. Additionally, because the data was based on participants' self-reported perceptions, personal biases may have influenced their responses, and financial aid leaders may have overestimated or underreported the importance of certain competencies based on perceived expectations. Moreover, with a response rate of 13.48%, there is a possibility of nonresponse bias, potentially limiting the generalizability of the findings. Additionally, the quantitative survey design restricts the ability to capture deeper, nuanced insights into the lived experiences, motivations, and developmental journeys of financial aid leaders that qualitative methods such as interviews or case studies may illuminate. This study also focused specifically on public institutions; thereby, the findings may not fully apply to private or for-profit environments. Recognizing these limitations provides important context for interpreting the results and identifying future research directions.

Implications for Practice

The findings of this study lend themselves to several actionable implications for enhancing intentional, adaptive, and inclusive leadership and competency development within the financial aid profession. The demographic realities identified—particularly the aging leadership workforce—provide compelling justification for proactive succession planning strategies for financial aid leadership. As Bolton and Roy (2004) emphasize, succession planning is integral to organizational sustainability. Institutions should prioritize the identification and cultivation of emerging leaders by establishing transparent career pathways, structured training opportunities, and targeted competency development. Offering early-career professionals meaningful opportunities to build versatile skillsets can help develop a resilient pipeline prepared to meet future institutional demands.

Research Question 1 explored which competency areas financial aid leaders perceive as most critical to their success. Participants perceived all six of the competency areas as important to the financial aid leader role, highlighting the need for a comprehensive competency-based framework for succession planning efforts. Because leaders place the highest value on *Career Development* competencies, institutions and professional associations should prioritize programming that offers coaching, mentorship, and skill-building. These opportunities, particularly those underscoring cross-functional teamwork and strategic skill development, can ensure leaders remain adaptable, innovative, and collaborative. Similarly, the strong importance placed on *Technical Proficiency* competencies highlights the need for continuous, hands-on training to keep pace with evolving technologies.

In general, the transition of leadership should be a deliberate and supported process. Structured growth plans should include clear expectations for annual progress in competency

areas, and advancement opportunities may be linked to demonstrated gains in those domains. Institutions should construct succession plans around these competencies by developing performance rubrics and evaluation tools aligned with each area. These tools can be embedded into mentoring programs and professional development to ensure that aspiring leaders are systematically assessed and prepared. Programs may incorporate rotational assignments, particularly in technical operations and compliance, and pair emerging leaders with seasoned mentors who demonstrate proficiency in key competency areas. Additionally, it may be helpful to encourage or require the attainment of NASFAA certifications and other credentials as developmental milestones.

Equitable access to leadership pathways must be a central consideration, particularly considering this study's findings that competency perceptions vary by race/ethnicity, gender identity, and age. Institutions should audit existing practices to identify barriers and promote diverse mentoring and leadership development models. Creating readiness assessment tools grounded in the six competencies can support succession planning by offering structured self-assessments and guiding individualized coaching. Additionally, to mitigate disruptions caused by staff turnover or regulatory change, institutions must institutionalize knowledge transfer. This includes developing standard operating procedures, visual training materials, and shadowing opportunities to preserve institutional memory. Complementary data-informed strategies—such as performance metrics, 360-degree feedback, and self-assessments—should be used to identify high-potential leaders early and tailor development efforts to institutional context. This is important since organizational and institutional contexts shape the demands placed on campus leaders (Hossler & Kemerer, 1986).

This study identified nuanced variations in how competencies are perceived, emphasizing the need for tailored and targeted leadership programs. For example, institutional characteristics, such as staff size, were shown to influence competency priorities. Leaders in larger offices (16–20 staff members) placed statistically significantly higher importance on *Career Development* compared to leaders in smaller offices (1–5 or 6–10 staff members). This suggests that leaders in larger offices may face heightened demands related to talent management, mentoring, and skill-building for themselves and others, while leaders in smaller offices may prioritize cross-training, role flexibility, and individual growth given their leaner organizational structures. Professional development programs should reflect these contextual differences by offering differentiated tracks adapted to specific operational needs. Additionally, findings related to years of experience and its influence on perceptions for *Business of Education* competencies imply that professional development programs should intentionally address this competency area early in leaders' careers, providing targeted training that helps them contextualize financial aid operations within the larger institutional framework. Additionally, development pathways should remain sensitive to the potential de-emphasis of business acumen among mid-to-late-career leaders, offering opportunities to refresh and apply this knowledge in mentoring or strategic planning contexts.

The differences in how financial aid leaders perceive the importance of *Laws and Regulations* competencies as a function of age carry additional implications for practice. Leaders aged 65 and older rated regulatory knowledge as more critical than those aged 25-34 and 35-44, with leaders aged 45-54 also emphasizing it more than the 35-44 age group. Given that older leaders value regulatory knowledge more highly, one practical implication is that professional development programs may integrate multigenerational approaches. Mentorship programs could pair older, experienced leaders with younger professionals to transfer regulatory expertise and

understanding. In turn, younger leaders can share insights into emerging technologies or innovative student success strategies. By acknowledging the perception differences based on years of experience and age, institutions and associations can better shape competency development efforts, ensuring that all leaders—regardless of years of experience or age—are equipped to navigate the demands of their role.

Importantly, programs should integrate content and experiential opportunities that reflect the lived experiences of individuals, ensuring that development efforts are inclusive, culturally responsive, and relevant. Women and non-White leaders in this study frequently rated a broad range of competencies as more important, potentially reflecting increased pressures, performance expectations or structural inequities that they navigate. Leadership development programs should be designed to foster equitable participation and reduce systemic barriers to advancement, and institutions must build genuine capacity to support, develop, and retain leader of all backgrounds—thereby strengthening organizational resilience and innovation. One exemplary model aligned with these needs is NASFAA's Diversity Leadership Program (DLP) (NASFAA, n.d.-e). The DLP provides participants from diverse backgrounds with one-on-one mentorship, national conference participation, committee engagement, and specialized leadership training. Programs like the DLP not only foster individual skill development but also expand access to professional networks, increase leadership representation, and amplify underrepresented voices within the financial aid profession.

However, the long-term success and impact of such initiatives depends on active awareness, endorsement, and engagement. Without widespread institutional support, programs like the DLP risk being underutilized or undervalued. To maximize their effectiveness, financial aid offices must increase the visibility of these opportunities, encourage eligible staff to apply,

and provide financial and logistical support for participation. Moreover, institutions should explicitly integrate such program participation into succession planning, performance evaluations, and broader talent development strategies. Professional associations likewise play a crucial role in strengthening outreach efforts and ensuring that institutional leaders understand the long-term benefits of investing in the development of their financial aid personnel. By integrating focused competency development, adjusting programs to nuanced institutional and demographic contexts, and embedding inclusive practices, institutions and professional associations can meaningfully strengthen financial aid leadership pipelines. These efforts not only enhance institutional effectiveness but also ensure that financial aid leadership increasingly reflects and serves the diverse needs of today's higher education landscape.

It is equally important to note how the findings of this study suggest opportunities for greater cross-functional integration within strategic enrollment management (SEM) as a whole. The competencies identified in this study—particularly *Career Development* and *Leadership Skills*—align with those emphasized across related SEM units such as admissions, advising, and student success (AACRAO, n.d.; Giblin & Morris, 2021; NACE, 2024). Harmonizing competency frameworks across associations may enable the creation of shared training resources and joint professional development initiatives. This approach would not only strengthen competency development but also increase awareness of the variety of career paths within SEM. This could be particularly valuable in addressing employee retention and succession planning—raising the profile of financial aid as a profession, while simultaneously broadening the horizons of professionals in other SEM sectors. As Mehrabani and Mohamad (2011) observed, organizations are increasingly fluid and flatter, requiring succession planning models that develop a broad pool of competent individuals for a range of leadership roles. By casting a wider

net and adopting an integrated, cross-functional approach to competency development and succession planning, benefits may be felt by both individuals and institutions.

Fostering leadership capacity within financial aid requires shared commitment among individuals, supervisors, and institutions. Financial aid leaders must take ownership of their professional growth by pursuing development opportunities, seeking mentorship, and remaining current with evolving regulations and best practices. However, their success is also shaped by the support and intentionality of supervisors and organizational leadership. Supervisors play a critical role in modeling effective leadership, offering constructive feedback, and creating growth opportunities aligned with institutional priorities (Bolton & Roy, 2004; George, 2010; Kouzes & Posner, 2010; Northouse, 2015). At the organizational level, institutions bear the ultimate responsibility for cultivating a culture that prioritizes leadership development through intentional investment in training, succession planning, and role clarity (Mehrabani & Mohamad, 2011; Bolton & Roy, 2004). Therefore, leadership development is most effective when approached as a collaborative endeavor that integrates personal initiative with systemic support.

Future Research

This study points to several promising directions for future research. Qualitative approaches, such as interviews and focus groups, could provide deeper insights into the lived experiences of financial aid leaders, particularly those from underrepresented groups. These methods can uncover the nuanced challenges, strategies, and personal narratives that shape competency and leadership development. For example, qualitative studies might explore how leaders navigate barriers related to gender, race, or institutional context, offering insights that could inform the design of more tailored leadership development programs. Additionally, future

qualitative research could explore the rationale behind the prioritization of certain competencies, to better understand the rankings that were revealed in this study.

Conducting longitudinal research would allow for examination of how financial aid leaders' perceptions and competencies evolve over time. Examining how leadership priorities shift across early, mid, and late career phases, or how critical institutional events—such as policy reforms, enrollment pressures, or structural changes—shape leadership demands, would provide dynamic insights. Longitudinal research could examine how competency development affects office outcomes, staff performance, and student success over time. For example, does participation in leadership development programs lead to improvement in outcomes such as leader confidence, team performance, compliance success, and staff retention? Evaluating the impact and effectiveness of specific initiatives such as NASFAA's Diversity Leadership Program (DLP) could also generate evidence on which components—mentorship, committee participation, or conference involvement—contribute most meaningfully to skill development, career progression, or organizational success. Results can inform modifications to existing programming or the design of new initiatives.

It would also be beneficial to conduct comparative studies across public, private, and for-profit institutions, or across diverse geographic or cultural settings, to reveal how organizational environments influence competency needs and leadership practices. Doing so would also test whether the identified competency rankings hold across different educational settings. Institutional mission, governance structures, available resources, and student demographics likely shape the specific demands placed on financial aid leaders, and understanding these differences would support the development of contextually relevant training approaches. Replicating this study in other areas of student affairs and enrollment management, such as

admissions, registrar, student life, or academic advising, also represent a possible future direction. This would help to uncover whether similar patterns of competency importance, development pathways, and demographic or institutional influences emerge across SEM leadership roles. Such research could generate valuable cross-functional insights that help institutions strengthen leadership development strategies holistically across departments.

Finally, as the higher education landscape continues to evolve, research should investigate emerging competencies required for effective leadership in the years ahead. Topics such as data analytics, artificial intelligence, digital communication, crisis management, and mental health and well-being are likely to become increasingly prominent. Examining how leaders are preparing for and integrating new demands will ensure that professional development efforts remain forward-looking and aligned with the changing needs of higher education.

Conclusion

In conclusion, this study advances understanding of financial aid leadership by offering an empirically grounded, theoretically informed examination of the competencies most valued by financial aid leaders, how perceptions differ as a function of various individual and contextual characteristics, and the methods by which competencies are developed. By connecting the findings to leadership theory and prior research, the study reinforces the multifaceted nature of financial aid leadership. It also highlights the importance of intentional, inclusive, and adaptable professional development strategies. These insights are highly relevant for financial aid leaders, institutional administrators, and professional associations seeking to strengthen leadership pipelines and enhance institutional effectiveness. Looking ahead, this study provides a strong foundation for future research and practice aimed at preparing the next generation of financial aid leaders to meet the evolving demands of higher education.

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APPENDICES

APPENDIX A: Survey Questionnaire

Competencies for Financial Aid Leaders in Higher Education

Introduction

The primary intent of this study is to understand how financial aid leaders perceive the importance of professional competencies to success in their role and how they are developed. In the following section, you will be asked to provide basic demographic information. Then, you will be asked to assess the importance of various competencies to success as a financial aid leader using a 4-point Likert scale and indicate the method(s) you have found most useful in developing those competencies. Please answer these questions truthfully to help us gain valuable insights.

If you have any questions about this survey, you can contact the researcher, Megan Chaffee, at mchaffee@govst.edu or the Principal Investigator, Dr. Deborah King, at dking9@govst.edu. If you have any questions regarding your rights as a research participant, you may contact the Governors State University Institutional Review Board (IRB) at 708-235-2147 or irb@govst.edu.

Demographic Information

Do you work as a Financial Aid Leader at a public college or university in the United States? (Financial Aid Leader is defined as the person holding the highest position within the Financial Aid Office, responsible for overseeing the office and leading all financial aid officers.)

- ☐ Yes
- ☐ No

How many years have you served as a Financial Aid Leader (at any institution)?

- ☐ Less than 1 Year
- ☐ 1-5 Years
- ☐ 6-10 Years
- ☐ 11-15 Years
- ☐ 16-20 Years
- ☐ 20+ Years

What is your current institutional type?

- ☐ Public 2-Year
- ☐ Public 4-Year Only
- ☐ Public 4-Year & Above

What is your current institutional size?

- ☐ Fewer than 500 full-time equivalent (FTE) students
- ☐ 500–1,999 FTE students
- ☐ 2,000–4,999 FTE students
- ☐ 5,000–9,999 FTE students
- ☐ 10,000+ FTE students

What is your current institutional region? (State groupings match those used by NASFAA's regional associations.)

- ☐ **Eastern** – Connecticut, Delaware, District of Columbia, Maryland, Maine, Massachusetts, New Hampshire, New Jersey, New York, Pennsylvania, Rhode Island, Vermont
- ☐ **Midwest** – Illinois, Indiana, Iowa, Michigan, Minnesota, Missouri, Ohio, West Virginia, Wisconsin
- ☐ **Rocky Mountain** – Colorado, Kansas, Montana, Nebraska, North Dakota, South Dakota, Utah, Wyoming
- ☐ **Southern** – Alabama, Florida, Georgia, Kentucky, Mississippi, North Carolina, South Carolina, Tennessee, Virginia
- ☐ **Southwest** – Arkansas, Louisiana, New Mexico, Oklahoma, Texas
- ☐ **Western** – Alaska, Arizona, California, Idaho, Nevada, Oregon, Hawaii, Washington

What is the current number of staff in your Financial Aid Office (including yourself)?

- ☐ 1-5
- ☐ 6-10
- ☐ 11-15
- ☐ 16-20
- ☐ 21+

What is your gender identity?

- ☐ Man
- ☐ Woman
- ☐ Non-Binary
- ☐ Prefer not to respond

Which race/ethnicity best describes you?

- ☐ American Indian or Alaskan Native
- ☐ Asian / Pacific Islander
- ☐ Black or African American
- ☐ Hispanic
- ☐ White / Caucasian
- ☐ Race/Ethnicity Not Listed
- ☐ Prefer not to respond

What is your age?

- ☐ 18 to 24
- ☐ 25 to 34
- ☐ 35 to 44
- ☐ 45 to 54
- ☐ 55 to 64
- ☐ 65 and over

Professional Competencies

Note: As you review the various competencies, please consider their importance specifically as they relate to the financial aid leader role. When selecting the method(s) and resource(s) that were most effective for you in developing these competencies, you may find that multiple options apply; if this is the case, please select your top three options.

Laws & Regulations	Not Important	Somewhat Important	Important	Very Important
Financial aid legislative and regulatory knowledge	O	O	O	O
Ethical compliance with Title IV program requirements	O	O	O	O
Correlation of multiple sources of aid	O	O	O	O
Advocacy in public policy	O	O	O	O

What method(s) and resource(s) did you find most effective for developing competencies related to Laws & Regulations? You may select up to 3 options.

- ☐ Formal Education (Degree/Certificate Program)
- ☐ National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA) Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program
- ☐ Federal Student Aid (FSA) Training Center Learning Tracks/Training Courses
- ☐ NASFAA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, AskRegs Database)
- ☐ FSA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, Student Aid Handbook)
- ☐ Other Conferences and Webinars (Not hosted by NASFAA or FSA)
- ☐ Industry-Related Materials (Books, Journals, Blogs, Podcasts)
- ☐ Networking/Mentorship
- ☐ Job Shadowing/Cross-Training

Career Development	Not Important	Somewhat Important	Important	Very Important
Professional growth and development	O	O	O	O
Collaboration	O	O	O	O
Teamwork	O	O	O	O
Developing skills for oneself and others	O	O	O	O

What method(s) and resource(s) did you find most effective for developing competencies related to Career Development? You may select up to 3 options.

- ☐ Formal Education (Degree/Certificate Program)
- ☐ National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA) Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program
- ☐ Federal Student Aid (FSA) Training Center Learning Tracks/Training Courses
- ☐ NASFAA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, AskRegs Database)
- ☐ FSA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, Student Aid Handbook)
- ☐ Other Conferences and Webinars (Not hosted by NASFAA or FSA)
- ☐ Industry-Related Materials (Books, Journals, Blogs, Podcasts)
- ☐ Networking/Mentorship
- ☐ Job Shadowing/Cross-Training

Leadership Skills	Not Important	Somewhat Important	Important	Very Important
Strategic Thinking	O	O	O	O
Planning	O	O	O	O
Critical Thinking	O	O	O	O
Problem Solving	O	O	O	O
Decision Making	O	O	O	O
Compromise	O	O	O	O
Change Management	O	O	O	O
Emotional Intelligence	O	O	O	O
Program Management	O	O	O	O
Stewardship	O	O	O	O

What method(s) and resource(s) did you find most effective for developing competencies related to Leadership Skills? You may select up to 3 options.

- ☐ Formal Education (Degree/Certificate Program)
- ☐ National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA) Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program

- ☐ Federal Student Aid (FSA) Training Center Learning Tracks/Training Courses
- ☐ NASFAA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, AskRegs Database)
- ☐ FSA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, Student Aid Handbook)
- ☐ Other Conferences and Webinars (Not hosted by NASFAA or FSA)
- ☐ Industry-Related Materials (Books, Journals, Blogs, Podcasts)
- ☐ Networking/Mentorship
- ☐ Job Shadowing/Cross-Training

Customer Service	Not Important	Somewhat Important	Important	Very Important
Communication Skills	O	O	O	O
Advising	O	O	O	O
Public Speaking	O	O	O	O
Financial Literacy	O	O	O	O
Cultural Competence	O	O	O	O
Flexibility	O	O	O	O
Empathy	O	O	O	O
Respect	O	O	O	O
Personal Responsibility	O	O	O	O

What method(s) and resource(s) did you find most effective for developing competencies related to <u>Customer Service</u>? You may select up to 3 options.

- ☐ Formal Education (Degree/Certificate Program)
- ☐ National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA) Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program
- ☐ Federal Student Aid (FSA) Training Center Learning Tracks/Training Courses
- ☐ NASFAA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, AskRegs Database)
- ☐ FSA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, Student Aid Handbook)
- ☐ Other Conferences and Webinars (Not hosted by NASFAA or FSA)
- ☐ Industry-Related Materials (Books, Journals, Blogs, Podcasts)
- ☐ Networking/Mentorship
- ☐ Job Shadowing/Cross-Training

Technical Proficiency	Not Important	Somewhat Important	Important	Very Important
Digital Communication	O	O	O	O
Electronic Processing	O	O	O	O
Leveraging Technology to Find Efficiencies Without Sacrificing Quality Service	O	O	O	O

What method(s) and resource(s) did you find most effective for developing competencies related to <u>Technical Proficiency</u>? You may select up to 3 options.

- ☐ Formal Education (Degree/Certificate Program)
- ☐ National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA) Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program
- ☐ Federal Student Aid (FSA) Training Center Learning Tracks/Training Courses
- ☐ NASFAA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, AskRegs Database)
- ☐ FSA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, Student Aid Handbook)
- ☐ Other Conferences and Webinars (Not hosted by NASFAA or FSA)
- ☐ Industry-Related Materials (Books, Journals, Blogs, Podcasts)
- ☐ Networking/Mentorship
- ☐ Job Shadowing/Cross-Training

Business of Education	Not Important	Somewhat Important	Important	Very Important
Institutional Context	O	O	O	O
Interdepartmental Practices	O	O	O	O
Collaboration	O	O	O	O
Relationship-Building	O	O	O	O
Exposure	O	O	O	O
Risk Assessment	O	O	O	O
Advocacy	O	O	O	O
Models of Governance	O	O	O	O
Models of Accreditation	O	O	O	O

What method(s) and resource(s) did you find most effective for developing competencies related to <u>Business of Education</u>? You may select up to 3 options.

- ☐ Formal Education (Degree/Certificate Program)
- ☐ National Association of Student Financial Aid Administrators (NASFAA) Certified Financial Aid Administrator Program
- ☐ Federal Student Aid (FSA) Training Center Learning Tracks/Training Courses
- ☐ NASFAA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, AskRegs Database)
- ☐ FSA Resources (Conferences, Webinars, Student Aid Handbook)
- ☐ Other Conferences and Webinars (Not hosted by NASFAA or FSA)
- ☐ Industry-Related Materials (Books, Journals, Blogs, Podcasts)
- ☐ Networking/Mentorship
- ☐ Job Shadowing/Cross-Training

This concludes the survey. The time and effort you have taken to participate in this research project is greatly appreciated. <u>Please click "Done" to submit your responses</u>. Thank you!

APPENDIX B: Institutional Review Board

Governors State UNIVERSITY

Institutional Review Board
Room G353
1 University Parkway
University Park, IL 60484
www.govst.edu/irb

Mar 25, 2025 10:16:49 AM CDT

Deborah King, Megan Chaffee
Education

Re: Exempt - Initial - IRB-FY2025-70 Competencies for Financial Aid Leaders in Higher Education

Dear Dr. Deborah King and Megan Chaffee:

The Governors State University Institutional Review Board has granted exempt approval for your project titled "Competencies for Financial Aid Leaders in Higher Education." You may begin your research.

- All research related to this project **must** be conducted **exactly** as stated in the approved research protocol
- If you would like to make any changes to research personnel or to the way that this research is conducted, you must completed a **Modification submission** and **wait for IRB approval** to enact any changes.
- Please be advised that you may **only** distribute the **GSU IRB approved** text, forms, documents, and materials to all participants. Your approved consent form and recruitment materials can be found under the "Attachments" tab on the "Study Details" page.
- After you have completed the project, please complete a **Project Closure submission**.
- Please include the assigned IRB project number, PI name, and exact title of your project in any correspondence about this project.

Decision: Exempt

Selected Category: Exemption Category Category 2.(i). Research that only includes interactions involving educational tests (cognitive, diagnostic, aptitude, achievement), survey procedures, interview procedures, or observation of public behavior (including visual or auditory recording) if at least one of the following criteria is met:
The information obtained is recorded by the investigator in such a manner that the identity of the human subjects cannot readily be ascertained, directly or through identifiers linked to the subjects;

Sincerely,
Governors State University Institutional Review Board
irb@govst.edu

APPENDIX C: Outreach Email

Dear Potential Participant,

My name is Megan Chaffee, and I am a doctoral student at Governors State University in Illinois. I am inviting you to participate in a survey about professional competencies for financial aid leaders and how they are acquired. The survey is part of a research study titled *Competencies for Financial Aid Leaders in Higher Education* being conducted by me, under the supervision of Dr. Deborah King, Principal Investigator.

Survey participants must be serving as the Financial Aid Leader at a public college or university in the United States. For this study, a Financial Aid Leader is defined as the person holding the highest position within the Financial Aid Office, responsible for overseeing the office and leading all financial aid officers. If this definition does not apply to you, please forward this information to the appropriate Financial Aid Leader at your institution.

The survey should take no more than 10 minutes to complete. You will be asked to assess the importance of various competencies to success as a financial aid leader using a 4-point Likert scale and indicate the method(s) you have found most useful in developing those competencies. Your basic demographic information will also be collected.

Participation in the survey is voluntary, and you may refuse to participate or exit the survey at any time.

Participation in the survey will not benefit you directly but will allow you to contribute to scholarship on financial aid leadership in higher education. The risk of participation in this survey is minimal; however, you should be aware that there is always a possibility of security breaches of data collected via the internet. We will make every effort to protect your responses once the data are downloaded from the internet. Your responses will remain confidential, and no identifying details (e.g., your name, contact information, or institutional affiliation) will be collected. Data will be reported only in aggregate form.

If you have any questions about this survey, you can contact the researcher, Megan Chaffee, at mchaffee@govst.edu or the Principal Investigator, Dr. Deborah King, at dking9@govst.edu. If you have any questions regarding your rights as a research participant, you may contact the Governors State University Institutional Review Board (IRB) at 708-235-2147 or irb@govst.edu.

By clicking on the survey link below, you are indicating that you are at least 18 years old, have read and understood this invitation, and agree to participate in this survey. Please print or save a copy of this invitation for your records.

Link to Survey: [SURVEY HYPERLINK]

Thank you for your important contribution to this study!

Sincerely,
Megan Chaffee
Ed.D. Candidate, Governors State University